Third Wheel

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by 7_penguins_eat_icecream

Summary

Stelle, throughout the entire time they had known each other, kept on telling him that everybody on Amphoreus needed a holiday, but apparently Phainon especially needed one. Something something something he had extreme trauma from reliving the same-ish 33 million gruelling cycles and falling in love again and again and again only to kill all those whom he loved again and again and again for that nigh impossible chance to stall the growth of Irontomb and figure out a way to stop the whole cosmos from imploding.

Phainon did not want to go on this “road trip” for a multitude of reasons.

Both Phainon and Aventurine get the holiday they desperately need; Phainon gets invited on a road trip and proceeds to get that weird blond stranger with that weird purple-haired doctor.

Notes

Please be warned that this fic is very spoiler heavy. Whilst my grip on whatever the fuck is going on with amphoreus is about as tight as the one Phainon has with his right arm (that is to say none), hope this makes somewhat coherent sense regardless if you truly understand the lore or not. So pls take everything in this fic with a grain of salt, or perhaps even an atom of salt.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Stelle, throughout the entire time they had known each other, kept on telling him that everybody on Amphoreus needed a holiday, but apparently Phainon especially needed one. Something something something he had extreme trauma from reliving the same-ish 33 million gruelling cycles and falling in love again and again and again only to kill all those whom he loved again and again and again for that nigh impossible chance to stall the growth of Irontomb and figure out a way to stop the whole cosmos from imploding.

Phainon did not want to go on this “road trip” for a multitude of reasons. He did not need it, first of all. The anger and love alike in his heart were all that was needed to sustain him. He also had other things to do, such as spending time rebuilding Amphoreus, trying to hang out with his friends without thinking of their fresh corpses and destroying Nanook into less than atoms. Lastly (for now, this was hardly an exhaustive list) Phainon did *not* want to be babysat by some doctor named *Ratio*, of all the names.

But no, Stelle had used her backseat therapy skills to declare that Phainon desperately needed a change of scenery and of people. And then they used one of his only remaining weaknesses: his dearest friends.

Aglaea had given him her blessings and told him to enjoy himself, and then strong-armed him into accepting the Nameless’ invitation. After all, how could he or Amphoreus ever heal if he never took a well-deserved rest? She then quietly reminded him that the Nameless were honoured guests.

Anaxa looked him up and down, grimaced, rolled his eye, then clasped his shoulder in an awkward but well-meaning gesture and told him: “Just fucking go.”

Phainon sighed. It seemed that all of his friends agreed with Stelle's idea. Having all of his loved ones live out the rest of their lives in the light of a new dawn was certainly a balm on the soul, but having everyone gang up on him was a *very* devious tactic. He begrudgingly respected Stelle’s cunning.

Of course, the final nail on the coffin was Mydei, striding forward to give Phainon a piece of his mind.

“You have done well, Deliverer. You deserve a rest. Weak and tired as you are now, you won’t pose any challenge to me.”

And then Mydei smirked, eyes crinkling at the edges. Like every time Phainon was seen as worthy of such a sight, his breath stilled in respect for such beauty. (He always treasured Mydei’s smile and his glinting golden eyes; even dying, he always forced himself to watch as they dulled into bronze.)

“Unless you're scared of going into the great unknown?” Mydei drawled, both of them knowing that Phainon was not scared of that. Mydei's smirk softened at the edges, opening up into the smile Phainon knew was for him alone. Then he used the sharp edge of his gauntlets to cut off the eternal plait that always framed his face. Without it, he looked a bit naked, that key defining characteristic gone for the first time. The blunt strands flared at the edges. Mydei then placed the plait in his hands. Not even a block of gold could ever compare to the dusky sunrise of his hair.

“For your silly pendant,” Mydei said, brows furrowed in embarrassment rather than anger.

“Alright. I'll go… but I can't guarantee these millennia-old shoulders can ever be rejuvenated, so I’ll need a bath or two when I come back.”

Mydei rolled his eyes fondly, and soon Phainon left on the Astral Express to some city known as Pier Point.

When the express disembarked only a scant hour later, Stelle briefly described what Ratio looked like: purple hair, orange eyes, tall, muscular and had one hell of a gyatt. Phainon wasn’t sure what a ‘gyatt’ was, but he had a couple of suspicions.

He was a tall, surprisingly muscular man for a devoted scholar (he carefully tried not to compare his stature to a certain someone) and was wearing a stone plaster head. Well, Phainon had seen stranger things — wait, was up with his clothing? Even Aglaea would approve of the mixed draping fabrics that wouldn’t look out of place being sold in Okhema’s markets, and the very tight and revealing cloth underneath.

“Have I seen him before…?” He mused to himself. Stelle gave him a fierce side eye, clearly fearing that his mind had fully broken at that specific moment.

Like any trained soldier, he took a quick, assessing glance at his surroundings. It was completely different from the general aesthetics found in Amphoreus, all smooth lines and grand, echoing spaces with tiled walls so polished in texture he could see smudges of his reflection in them. Phainon, of course, expected the skies beyond Amphoreus to be different, but he was admittedly hung up on the lack of pillars. After a couple of millennia, the scenery and the bodies blended together in shades of gold and white. Everything had become so *small.* His purpose had narrowed into one goal, the Eternal land became nothing less than a landmass to him.

He should have been marvelling at the opportunity to witness something new, but he was just…drained. For a while, he was completely drained of everything: his memories, his millennia-old purpose, his *fury.* Now, he was woefully out of his depth in new territory. If he could fully transition from living as a country bumpkin to a hero, he could endure the sudden perspective shift for three days.

He chided himself for his senseless nerves; he was far too old for that. Besides, he dealt with feeling like a small fish in a large ocean time and time and time again (perhaps Amphoreus

was more of a pond and Aedes Elysiae was more of a puddle—). Phainon consciously breathed in and out and in and out.

He focused on other things, such as Doctor Ratio striding towards him and Stelle.

“Ratio!” Stelle crowed, waving her hand around with the chaotic frenzy of an excitable chimera, nearly bashing Phainon’s head multiple times. With a slight grin that didn’t quite fit as well as it used to, Phainon waved his hand too, all too aware of how they were catching looks from everybody.

Ratio greeted her with an elegant marbled nod. “I’ve been told you’ve been unreachable ever since you reached the Eternal Land.” His voice changed to a steely register that gave Phainon flashbacks to his graduation(s). “Have you been doing your homework?”

With a nervous chuckle, Stelle patted him on the back before making her escape, somehow more scared of a scholar than the Titan of Death, Titan of the Skies, Titan of Strife, etc. Phainon understood immediately, and a rush of sympathy bloomed in the decrepit ruins of his charcoal heart.

“Hahahah, yeah, Phainon ate my homework when I got isekai’d as his childhood friend and snitched on him, but byeeeee! Great to see you again!”

For a singular second, Phainon mildly considered blowing her into smithereens. The second passed, and Phainon felt the urge to protect his honour in front of a scary scholar rise.

As if he weren’t a man who held onto his (dubious) sanity throughout 33 million iterations of all of his loved ones dying and then didn’t announce war on a whole ass aeon, Phainon awkwardly held out his hand, then hastily recalled that, hey, different planet, different customs, right?? Oh, may Kephale strike him down.

Ratio took his hand and shook it firmly. In his panic over trying not to implode, Phainon’s grip was weaker than a baby’s. Now he must seem like a dweeb, to use a certain traitor’s vernacular. He could practically hear his love laughing at him for his weak, cowardly grip. The completely unknown stranger did not laugh at him, just accepted the pathetic shake. He did not do much of anything, really. He was completely inscrutable due to his hidden face and because he never met him throughout 33 million cycles. Phainon did not intimately recognise the sound of his footsteps or how he would breathe out a laugh; Phainon did not know what he looked like dead.

Impatiently, Ratio gestured for Phainon to follow him. Directionless and lost, Phainon followed, thumbing the pendant as gently as he could.

Stelle: my bad for running out on you then, been spending so much time on Amph i thought he was gonna pull out a gun hahahbdhas

Stelle: tbf that chalk of his is wayyyy more scary but pls dont tell xanax that

Stelle: i know its hard to acclimate to a completely unknown place esp without any friends

Stelle: so just remember that im always just a call away <3

Stelle: remember to have fun!!!!

Phainon couldn't help but see the ghost of his loved ones everywhere he looked, but who could blame him? After all, he has been loving every single friend every single cycle with reckless abandon, even when his brain wished he could stop feeling, stop hurting every time he grabbed those golden coreflames from limp ribcages. Even in a whole different place, his love continues to pursue him like the scent of death and rot. It lingers, like how he sometimes can't quite get blood out from underneath his fingernails.

He looked at Ratio, and all he could think about was his old professor. On the surface, they were quite alike (the cavity that once held the coreflames ached fiercely). They both walked and spoke like they could never quite have enough time, as if every breath could be spent on something else worthy of their attention. They both breathed and lived with some hidden schedule only they could make sense of. Maybe Phainon was projecting; Anaxa would be very disappointed in him. But as they paced over to Ratio's car to start the road trip, Phainon took something akin to comfort in his blunt manner and sharp tongue and even sharper eyes.

As soon as they entered his car, his plaster head dissolved into nothing. Phainon drank in each feature to forcefully separate their conjoined images; it was unfair to Ratio to keep comparing him to somebody else that he may never meet. That, and Phainon really should have been paying attention to his words instead of surface-level similarities. Sometime after a couple thousand cycles, he could predict what each Chrysos Heir would say with 99% accuracy (he does not say 100% because Anaxa would rise even from the grave to give him another lesson on statistics and beat him up), which unfortunately gave him the bad habit of sometimes forgetting to tune back in with his ears. Of course, Phainon was planning on working on that minor issue.

The minute passed in awkward silence until Ratio made a pointed cough and glared at him. Unfortunately, his all too similar golden eyes make Phainon's heart lurch in its rib cage until he employed all of his determination to absolutely nuke that feeling.

"My apologies, professor." Is what slips out of Phainon's mouth on instinct. It's almost as embarrassing as the 33 million times Phainon accidentally called Anaxa 'dad'.

Then Ratio huffs out a suggestion of a laugh, his previously stony countenance (shame that Hyacine or Castorice wasn't there to laugh at his bad jokes) melting juuuuust a tad. Oh, thank goodness the horrors hadn't taken away all of Phainon's charisma.

"Professor? Well, I shall take that as a desire to learn from me, then." Ratio dryly commented before turning on his car, tapping at a couple of screens until it started to rumble beneath both of them.

Thankfully, Phainon gained a crash course on some common things that were found in the wider cosmos, by courtesy of the Astral Express, so he gracefully handled his first car ride even as he wondered what on Kephale's name prompted Stelle to describe this method of travelling as 'dromas but with gears.' It held absolutely no resemblance to a dromas, in

Phainon's humble opinion. It was far too steady and had a smell that wasn't unpleasant but certainly wasn't the (dubiously) fresh air of Pier Point. They started to move, and Phainon dutifully pointed out the traffic cones and lights to himself.

Ratio somehow manages to draw Phainon's eye in the mirror whilst stuck behind a red light. "Do you require medical assistance for your arm?" Phainon tries very hard to figure out what he's talking about. Ratio continues, "Pier Point Hospital's prosthetics are top of the range."

Oh yeah. Phainon stared at his stump. "Oh, there's no need to worry, Professor. It's a nice change of pace, y'know?"

The traffic light turned green, which meant he should be moving, but Ratio took a moment to do so. His face contorted in a wild flinch as he digested Phainon's response. Any emotion was swiftly removed within the next second.

"Pardon?" He asked in a tone that Phainon had heard from Anaxa many, many times before, like that one time Phainon's drunken escapades into writing real person fiction with Castorice about a certain professor got exposed. In every cycle but #12769, those sins were not found out by the muse of them.

"This is my first time with only one arm."

Phainon gave him a somewhat innocent smile that probably suited him better before he got 33 million cycles dumped into his head, but he really had to work with what he got. Ratio pinched his nose bridge with such despair that even Phainon was impressed. After a deep sigh, he awakened a new man.

"Alright then," he said, "would you mind if I invited somebody else on this trip?"

Ratio did not offer a reason, even after a beat of silence. Phainon wondered if he was going to hire a hitman or an emotional support being.

"No problem!" He replied, cautiously excited to meet another completely new face.

During another red light, the scholar quickly typed something on his phone and seemed to make a detour, suddenly driving left. He also turned off the mini screen depicting the path to follow.

"Don't you need to use navigation to plot a new journey?" Phainon asked, applying his new knowledge about travelling in a car to make sure he could remember the details to share later.

Ratio's mouth tightened at the edges. "... I've already memorised this particular path," he admitted.

The air went weird from one-sided embarrassment; Phainon was slowly connecting the dots.

"Stelle mentioned that you were a highly renowned scholar." he waited for an affirmation to continue, "I don't know what she has mentioned about my planet's background, but I lack knowledge of the cosmos' Aeons and Paths."

As he expected, any scholar worth their salt would be pleased with a student taking initiative.

“Normally, I would prefer for one to research such things on their own before asking, but considering your background, I shall make an exception. Is there any particular information you are seeking?”

“Thanks, Prof! I was thinking…” Phainon lost his weak smile and leaned forward, expression deathly still. “Do you know how to kill an aeon?”

“Why would you seek *that* information?” Ratio demanded with a straight face, nearly coming to a harsh stop in the middle of the road, which was maybe illegal or at least ill-advised. His next sentence was far quieter, his lips barely moving. “Now, this is highly sensitive information and you did not hear this from me, but only an Aeon can kill another, or through the collision of Paths.”

“Thank you,” Phainon whispered, mulling over the new information. So, if he wanted to destroy the Destruction, perhaps he should consider ascending to aeonhood to personally throw hands. He nodded to himself. But that raised another question: what would Phainon even become the aeon of?

In another hushed question, Phainon continued his interrogation, “How does one become an Aeon?”

“Talking about the known origins of the Aeons is hardly a controversial topic,” Ratio offered, now in his regular volume. Then, with a tone that truly suited lecture halls and debates, he regaled how Nanook ascended into aeonhood. Phainon focused on every word, internally losing his shit. Why would Ratio choose *Nanook* specifically, and why did he look like a local from Phainon’s homeworld?

As it turned out, Ratio *did* get an emotional support human in the shape of a handsome blond man wearing a vibrant shirt with a considerable amount of chest showing. Phainon wished *he* had his emotional support human in the shape of a handsome blond(ish) man wearing a vibrant shirt with a considerable amount of chest showing. Despite his envy, Phainon took a moment to appreciate the strange, saturated pink draconic birds on the stranger’s shirt.

Said man knocked on the driver’s window only a minute after Ratio stopped on the driveway to a sleek household that was reminiscent of the city’s train station, opulent and sanitised. Phainon stared at the incongruous marble statue that most certainly depicted the doctor he had just met. Maybe he should ask who the artist was so that Mydei’s graceful and otherworldly countenance could also be immortalised in the finest marble. Being so wrapped up in the image of a 60-foot Mydei statue, he completely missed Aventurine’s instinctual death stare at some hussy sitting at the back of Ratio’s car when Ratio invited *him* to a three-day holiday.

Once the new face settled into the seat beside Ratio, Phainon studied him, completely aware he was being studied in turn, lurid eyes swiftly catching the stump then returning to his face. He, as previously mentioned, was blond. But when the light behind him and his strands were

backlit with faded gold, all Phainon could think about was Aglaea's wavier, finer hair and her warm golden life essence spilling into golden water, dissipating into thin, fine threads—

The face changed from the immaculate veneer of a businessman with a polite yet oddly provoking smile to something confused. (Aglaea would not—) Then he reached awkwardly behind to offer a handshake, which was something Phainon could certainly do. He returned it automatically, blinking away the afterimages of her. It settled behind his eyelids anyway, like when one stared into the sun carried by Kephale's straining shoulders.

"Hello, *friend*, I am Aventurine," he said the title as if it were a threat, "of the—"

Ratio shot a glance at his partner and cleared his throat, stopping Aventurine in his tracks. "This is a *holiday*, Gambler, not a networking event."

Awwww, they even had nicknames for each other! (Phainon did not know if he wanted to laugh or sob whenever he heard or even thought of Mydei's nickname, a shackle, a testament to his dedication, an unwavering declaration of faith, all in one.) How cute!

"Y'know, Doc, I sure didn't expect you to be picking up strangers. Change of profession?" Aventurine joked, his gaze behind his pink sunglasses never leaving Phainon.

"I'm doing this as a favour from Stelle, but I invited you of my own accord," Ratio gently corrected, and Phainon was a very awkward intruder trying his best to melt into the background. Then, resolutely looking at nothing but the road ahead, "You mentioned that you wanted a holiday, and certainly not in Penacony."

Aventurine's face froze, his teasing smile twitching like a dying fly. He murmured out, "How sweet of you, doc." His weak attempt at playfulness was quite pitiful, but people trying to melt into the background did not draw attention to themselves, so he imagined what Mydei would say if he were subjected to such a scene.

Well, Mydei would say that Phainon was hardly better in the feelings or romance department. Oooh, self-burn. (Is that what a Self-Annihilator did? Phainon only had the hare-brained, no-context musings of the trailblazers to go off on.)

"So, Ratio, where are you taking us?" Aventurine's expression smoothed out to pleasant, distant neutrality.

"The beach." The scholar answered smoothly, only shooting a vaguely miffed look when Aventurine let out a playful laugh.

Aventurine's grin was quite smug when he teased, "All that talk about taking adequate rest breaks throughout the week, but you have no idea what to do on a proper vacation, do you, doctor? You're probably just following what those IPC travel pamphlets suggest, right?"

Ratio stayed conveniently silent.

"How long have you guys been together?" Phainon earnestly asked, watching their interactions as if it were one of those trashy flicks he liked to watch with Castorice on her

(better quality, very pristine, not cracked at all) teleslate. Aventurine's jaw closed with a quiet click.

Nobody spoke for the entirety of the car ride afterwards.

The Eternal DEEZ NUTS

(group chat with: Stelle, Dan Heng, Phainon)

Stelle: heyy how has the trip been so far?? have u had chalk thrown at u yet?

Phainon: Haha, it's only been a couple of hours, but so far so good. I believe we're going to the beach.

Stelle: oooooh nice, the only beach ive been in was scalegorge and that place was lowkey haunted af soz Dan Heng

Stelle: seems a bit boring with just two people tho

Dan Heng: No offence taken

Dan Heng: Hope you have a nice time, Phainon, the change of scenery may do you good

Phainon: Thanks, Grayie and Dannie! But it's not just us three, Ratio invited another person named Aventurine? Do you know him too?

Stelle: AYO WHAT

Stelle: WHAT IN THE CUTSLEEVE IS THIS.

Stelle: well they already have three fur babies lol

Phainon: Apparently they are not a couple. Maybe they are in a situationship? Am I using that term correctly?

Dan Heng: Yes

Stelle: AYO NOT PHAINON OF AEDES ELYSIAE, PHAINON THE DAWN DENIED HERO, THE SLAYER OF IRONTOMB, HE WHO SCRATCHED NANOOK BEING A THIRD WHEEL

Stelle: bro please you gotta matchmake them i thought they were together broooooo

Phainon: Haha, I'm afraid it would be quite rude of me to push. In hindsight, many of the Chrysos Heirs tried to matchmake Mydei and I, but were very unsuccessful, so I doubt my best efforts would help much.

Stelle: booooo

Phainon: It seems that you know Aventurine?

Stelle: he seems sketchy and he lowkey is, but not in an untrustworthy way. Like i would not trust him with my pen but i would with my bank balance

Dan Heng: Stelle he is a billionaire. I don't think your bank account matters to him

Phainon: Would he be the type to put Amphoreus under threat?

Stelle: nahhhh he good, wouldnt even care much about it from IPC view. Maybe yall could go on a life changing field trip together lol

Stelle: both of yall need it

The beach was a novelty to Phainon, who was born and raised and re-born and re-raised in Aedes Elysiae, where the biggest body of water was more of a lake and then lived the majority of his life in the city, but unfortunately, it was a novelty he was having mixed feelings on. There weren't many sandy places in Amphoreus, either, so the sensation of sand being *everywhere,* intruding upon every single millimetre of his skin, was not appreciated. However, the view *was* good, the limitless ocean crashing onto the coast, dragging wet sand backwards only to return it in the next motion.

Like Stelle and Dan Heng, he decided to take a couple of mementoes, taking a couple of photos, wincing at their blurriness. Well, at least his Teleslate still worked. When he showed off the photos to his friends, he'd likely have to defend his awful photography with vigour. Oh, Mydei would certainly make fun of him, and in turn, Phainon would demand a photography competition that would end with Mydei's victories outnumbering his by one.

Like how the glass bottle containing a young boy's wishes always drifted back to the craggly coast of Aedes Elysiae, Phainon's thoughts would always reach out to Mydei, in slumber and in peace and in war and in death. This time, he wished Mydei could see a gentle ocean with warm currents and even warmer sand with no monsters lurking underneath. But then again, Mydei would find such scenery boring after a while. He'd take better pictures, though, eyes and hands trained from years of carefully curating his secret social media posts.

His eyesight naturally turned to the fresh disturbance. His new scholarly acquaintance rose out of the sea like an overly dramatic depiction of Mnestia gliding from the sea, torso bared and water glistening in the sun. Already having a solid idea of what to expect, Phainon observed how the blond man sunbathing on the sand was watching the sight with more focus than necessary. Phainon was certainly being far too nosy — he had only known them for several hours. Maybe it was precisely because of the minute timeframe he had known them that had driven him to such madness. They were *very* new to him, and every act they committed would be unknown to him because he had no idea who they were yet, which was beginning to culminate in a desire to push them together to see what disaster or miracle would bloom.

Ratio walked over to where Aventurine lay on a pristine beach chair, sprawled like a spider on its web, and leaned over to ask something. Phainon kicked at the water and watched as the

droplets merged with the spume and air, feeling a bit like a lost toddler trying to amuse themselves. Well, a toddler could be occupied by anything and everything, their buoyant hearts and imagination waiting for even the smallest bit of kindling. Alas, Phainon did not have such energy at that moment.

Phainon still doesn't understand what was supposed to be relaxing about the beach — was he supposed to watch the endless swash and backwash of the ocean 33 million times?

He shifted his feet in the coarse sand, grounding himself in the tickling sensation of grains smoothing below the sole of his feet. He soon had an idea for some proper relaxation and was almost disturbed by how obvious the idea was.

Quickly, the shifting susurrus of the sand alerted him to Ratio's presence.

"Hello," Phainon greeted, "is there anything I can do for you?"

"No. What would you like to eat? Something more familiar to you or something different entirely? It's currently lunchtime."

"Ah, thank you, but I don't need—"

His rebuttal was cut harshly by the sharp, mildly disappointed look that reminded him far too much of Anaxa. Like the overly sensitive plant Phainon had inadvertently killed 33 million times over, Phainon wilted.

"Yes, Prof." His mind scrambled to find something that should be easy to find, he'd like to eat, even when he no longer required such sustenance. What would be easy to find in Pier Point? He'd forgotten what it felt like to be a complete stranger to an unknown land by now, unsettled by the initial discomfort of not knowing the streets and houses like the palm of his hand.

Eyes sharpened in focus, Ratio pondered on what to do with the buffering man in front of him.

"I'm having fried sea bass and coconut rice from a restaurant nearby. I've had it before and can vouch for its quality."

"That sounds great, thank you!" Phainon said on instinct; his mother hadn't raised him with bad manners, after all, even if he had fumbled a bit hours before. With a strained chuckle, he admitted he still did not have any cosmic currency except for one (1) singular credit courtesy of Stelle, but tried to sneak a gold coin into Ratio's pockets the moment he turned around.

Ratio dodged each attempt without breaking a sweat, almost unnervingly unbothered. "There is no need to repay me."

"Please, Professor! It's a cultural thing, I absolutely cannot allow myself to mooch off of you!"

Somehow sensing Phainon's lies like an overpowered chimera trained to sniff out dishonesty and trickery, Ratio raised a brow, and his expression conveyed that he wanted no further

objections. “Somebody has already beaten you in your unnecessary race to pay. Bye.”

“Uhm, bye!”

Phainon vowed to sneak 100 gold coins into Ratio’s bag. Somehow. He didn’t even have 5 gold coins to his name, actually. He was broke as fuck, to put it mildly.

Rather than dwelling on his unfortunate financial situation (and all of the impulsive purchases of historical phonies that created such a situation), Phainon summoned his greatsword and went through his simpler sword moves, taking his time to adjust the motions for just one arm. In the heat of battle, he figured such things out on the fly, powered by millennia of accumulated battle prowess and sheer wrath. Now, he could afford to take things a bit slower and more smoothly.

The new terrain pulled him from the past — Phainon didn’t know how he had never trained his swordsmanship in the sand before, but the divots of sand he left in his wake were satisfying. Grains flew from the ground with each swing, the surface of the ocean rippled, and its foam sliced briefly, reforming within the next second. In his violent meditation, all thoughts and doubts and hatred were rendered null; perhaps conflict was the only thing he’d ever truly understand. Sparring with his lover, however, was always fun. (Well, until Mydeimos was nothing more than a titan with a coveted coreflame to the dawn-denied one).

He breathed out, let the fine salty mist settle in his lungs, and continued until his mundane form worked up a sweat. In the presence of guests, Phainon thought it would be rude to lose himself completely, so he released his greatsword and started his stretches with a tempered, ritualistic focus. He sought out the movement of his muscles and his lungs. He took a quick dunk in the water, nerves alight with the brutal coolness.

Once he was presentable, he decided to talk to his mysterious companion. Considering how those bejewelled eyes hadn’t left his direction, Phainon guessed it would be the right choice. Phainon may have only been in Aventurine’s presence for less than a day, but his sharp, assessing gaze hidden by a pretty, unassuming face reminded him of Aglaea. He swears it isn’t just because they were both blonde.

They both greeted each other as he came closer to the wooden chairs and he was quite glad that greetings across the cosmos seemed to be similar: a smile and a nod and meandering small talk. Hovering like some awkward fly, Phainon tapped his fingers against the chair’s arm as if trying to flick away the flaky remnants of the gold that plagued him constantly.

“Greatswords are quite an uncommon choice,” Aventurine commented, his mirrored sunglasses (a fashion fad that never stuck in Okhema, much to his disappointment. Aglaea would never let him wear them in peace.) glinting like a sword’s edge.

“They’re pretty popular in my world,” Phainon replied, despairing at his flaky, traitorous charisma.

“You use it like an extension of your own body.”

“Yeah, I’ve been practising swordsmanship for a long, long time.”

For a blistering moment, Phainon wished for whatever passing Aeon around to smite him to the ground; to think that everybody used to agree he talked too much.

“You know,” Phainon said with a smile that almost felt natural, “I could teach you.”

Aventurine barked out a harsh laugh, nearly choking on his water. “Good heavens,” he muttered raspily, then smoothed out his face and voice, “friend, I’m certainly not a warrior nor do I have the strength to swing it around even once.”

Phainon chuckled lightly, knowing damn well that whilst Aventurine might not be the picture of heroism (neither was he — that title belonged to Mydei, of course), he was certain that Aventurine was stronger than he seemed and had spilt blood numerous times and wouldn’t hesitate to do it again if necessary. Something in those battle-weary eyes of his that mirrored his own. Or maybe he was just projecting. Again.

Luckily, Ratio finally made it back, a large bag carrying all the containers, sitting down at the foot of Aventurine’s beach chair. Phainon eagerly dug in, pausing when he tasted unfamiliar spices. Ultimately, they were good, and he had never been a picky eater, so he continued to eat, albeit with tastebuds that were very confused from trying something new after eating the same-ish cuisine for a long time.

“I have a question,” Phainon said after a pause.

“Do go on.” Ratio replied, still eating at his own pace. Phainon noted that Aventurine was a far quicker eater than he was.

“What’s Pier Point like? And the food here, too? The fish was as good as you said it would be, Prof, thank you!”

Ratio offered nothing else but, “Aventurine has stayed here far longer than I have. He’ll likely have the answers you are looking for.”

“Well, thanks for the vote of confidence, Ratio.” Behind his glasses, Aventurine narrowed his eyes in confusion. “You want to know *that*? Well, I’m no Ratio but… well, this place is the headquarters of the IPC. Most of the people living here are IPC employers, including me. As Ratio also works under the IPC sometimes, he was given an apartment here. Not much to say about the food here, most things from the wider cosmos can be found here. There are restaurants here, too, of course, like the Kiliro Fish Restaurant that Ratio just went to. Most eat at restaurants after work; the lunch break's usually too short.”

After a pause, he then added, “I can go even further in depth if you want.”

Phainon shook his head, “Ah, no need, my curiosity has been sated! It’s always cool to learn how food culture differs from region to region.”

Ratio nodded thoughtfully, “Willing to share any examples?”

“For starters, I'm what's called a country bumpkin.” Phainon waited to see if that term was used or at least understandable; from the twitch of a smile from his audience, Phainon guessed it was. “I grew up in the rural countryside of Aedes Elysiae. There wasn’t a sea of flowers or even a sea in general, but there was a sea of wheat every harvest season. When I had to move away to the city, I remember being strangely surprised by the different food, especially the dromas steak.”

As a generally good conversationalist when he wasn't planning on being antagonistic, Aventurine picked up the line of inquiry. “A dromas? I haven't heard that one before.”

As if the spirit of The Great Performer Anaxa, the infamous Dromas Draped in Finery, was looming over him with his pistol pointing right at his skull, Phainon tried to pay homage to the humble and amazing and the menacing four-legged beast. Judging from the carefully blank face from his main target (he had taken off his sunglasses, either to convey judgement or scrutiny or even to focus better), Aventurine was very much not understanding his description of *a very gentle, but honestly very viscous beast the size of an average house — ok, so smaller than the apartments I see around here, so picture a very big lizard but with longer legs, like that of an ancient tree, they have tails like a lizard, too, but they do not move in a lizard fashion, they are the type of beast that bumbles around more than scurries — imagine such a beast scurrying around the streets of Okhema!*

Aventurine summoned a coin made of Imaginary, then twirled it around his fingers and reached behind Phainon’s head.

“Is this your card?”

Aventurine flicked out a faintly glowing card, dark brown with tasteful streams of gold. He grinned, summoning others to form a fan, then revealed the pictures on the back: an extremely fucked up komodo dragon-esque creature with sharp fangs. Phainon, for the first time in far too long, broke into a peal of laughter.

“But seriously,” Aventurine dramatically complained, “your description makes no sense!”

From then, they worked on the depiction of what could be politely described as an unfortunate dromas-chimera that went horribly wrong, Phainon quickly describing the features that were entirely missing, such as their vivid colouring, ranging from purple to blue, and their patterning.

Aventurine gave them a most awful puce colour, one evocative of dreadful illness and despair. “Well, the living ones have a bit more colour in them, but it’s a great start!” Aventurine shuffled the cards, now showing off a colour that no gentle thing in the wilds could naturally produce. “Well, they are the colour of twilight, the gentle bridge between the night and day, a holy beacon guiding humanity forward.” Aventurine's smile widened. The next card’s dromas looked like Kokopo III in terms of colour and ferocity, but nothing else.

They continued the game until they hit a rut, in which Phainon could no longer help Aventurine beyond a vague ‘the white spots are less like weird pimples, more like little rocks embedded in them’. Even Phainon was beginning to lose hope; he was beginning to worry

that his inability to praise the humble and wise dromas would somehow be sniffed out by Anaxa within a minute of them meeting again.

With the most exasperated yet stony expression Phainon had ever seen, Ratio created a perfect depiction of a dromas, complete with gentle eyes, their stubby little toenails Phainon kept on forgetting to mention, their funny little rocky eyebrows and a wagging tail. Its proportions were perfect. Their scales were perfect. As if nothing had happened, Ratio took a sip of his water.

What the [Aedes Elysiae expletive]

“We’re going to Pier Point Museum.” Ratio stated as he ushered them into his car again, and Phainon knew there was no other option; not that he was complaining, as he was pretty eager to learn about history in other worlds now that he had time.

Aventurine hummed in thought, turned again to Ratio. “I heard the monthly exhibit is on the Swarm Disaster, wanna go check it out?” As expected, the latter part was directed to Ratio.

“Of course,” the doctor replied as if there was no other option, “but if the quality is anything like last month’s exhibit, then I will be sorely disappointed.”

“You’re never going to let go of that, are you?” Aventurine said softly, lips curved ever so gently upwards.

Ratio huffed in amusement before diving into a short explanation of the Swarm Disaster and the Aeon of Propagation.

Phainon was heavily debating whether to ask *hey, so how often do you guys go on dates to the museum* and *hey, could Mydei and I come along next time for a double date that would hopefully pull both of your heads out of your asses* but as he did not want to make the atmosphere strange again, he kept mum — not because he had nothing to say, but because he was plotting. Scheming, even. They (the other Chrysos Heirs) may jokingly call him the son of a divorced couple, but that was *not* going to stop Phainon from making a couple out of them, no matter how hard it may be! If there was one thing Phainon knew, it was the indomitable human spirit and Mydei’s fantastic tits.

No, this was not him avoiding his own issues by distraction. He just had to repeat that enough times to fully believe it.

Chapter End Notes

ty for checking this fic out! <3

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> btw kokopo III is the name of Mydei's dromas, who missed him very much when he had to leave. Hes in one of the world quests that i still havent done oof.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It seemed that one of the constants of the unfeeling universe was the cycle of destruction-survival-reconstruction-destruction of societies and worlds. Even the singular planet of Amphoreus was no stranger to the complete annihilation of the more unfortunate cities, until there was only one left. Aedes Elysiae, Dolos, The Grove of Epiphany, Aidonia were all left as mere bones of themselves. And then reset again and again—

Phainon hadn't accounted for the sheer number of extinct planets and peoples across the cosmos. To think that a singular Aeon could account for such death, to think that Tayzzyronth was stopped only by several other Aeons. Humanity never seemed so unbearably small. However, Phainon was standing in Pier Point and was very much alive. Not even the Swarm could fully decimate the cosmos, and even Amber Eras later, there were still remnants of the fallen civilisations.

Behind the thin glass, a pair of shoes, weathered and clearly handmade, were placed on display. During the Swarm Disaster, there were records of a mother who, grieving her children, tried to have the bugs wear shoes. She failed.

A soft, mourning breath later, Phainon wrenched his gaze from that particular exhibit, absently appraising the other objects in that particular room: dinner plates, blankets, mugs, chairs, a doll. The Swarm had been hunting for food in their mindless propagation, and so the non-edible objects like the dinner plates were left mostly undamaged, and if they were not intact, it was because of the owners dropping or cracking them in their haste to evacuate. The blankets were left half-eaten, for when the bugs recognised that it wouldn't provide them with the nutrition they were searching for, it was already too late.

If he concentrated, he could hear the distant hum of the professor and the businessman's conversation. Glancing only slightly to the side, he saw that Ratio was likely delivering another lecture, this time to his situationship. Whilst he was grateful for the plethora of information Ratio had willingly given him, he also needed some time alone to absorb everything. Also, why would anyone in their right mind measure time with *Amber Eras,* aka whenever Qlipoth dropped their hammer. Like, where was the regularity?! Ratio was a kindred spirit in that aspect, at least.) The universe was *wild.* And quite desolate and depressing, but, most importantly, full of love and hope. That last part was very important to remember.

(Amphoreus was a dying land pulsing with a bitter, tenuous hope that may have frayed but never broke completely. And if a hero could be described as the beating heart of the city, Phainon gripped onto that thread, that singular vein, until the storm had finally passed.)

He stared at the portrait of the Sand King, the Aeon of Propagation. To become so lonely and bitter that you ascend from the sheer grief, becoming a shell filled with a cosmic hatred that *burned*. (His shoulder blades itched; the ripped seams of his useless wings itched.)

“Friend, you don’t look so good.”

Phainon let out a choppy breath, instinctual flex of his right hand rendered null due to it not existing anymore — not that it stopped him from feeling it. He turned around, where Aventurine lurked several metres away.

“I’m fine,” he lied.

Aventurine’s all too suspicious and knowing gaze travelled up and down his face, taking in the trembling pupils and trembling mouth. His gaze dared him to lie further.

Phainon rescinded his earlier words; he might as well give him something, even if no words could quite capture the fury and disgust trembling through his nerves. “It’s just… There's so much grief in the world. I hoped that my homeworld was the exception, one of the only planets to suffer from so many lost cities.”

Aventurine’s eyes also lingered on the Sand King, the copies of a once-extinct species congregating in such a dense swarm that they became one entity. “I’m afraid the universe is as inherently unjust as you feared.”

His eyes glistened like the carapace of a beetle, vivid and damp colours colliding into each other, an old, bone-deep tiredness and apathy threatening to spill over. Then Aventurine put his sunglasses back on and walked into the next room, and the illusion was shattered. Phainon sought out Ratio, only to find him to his left, observing the little boots. The museum wasn’t too busy at that hour: it was 3:30 on a Monday. He and Ratio were the only ones in the section. He mulled over the blond's parting words for a moment.

Keeping his voice low, Phainon said, “You and Aventurine sure are close.”

Of course, Ratio neither confirmed nor denied anything, knowing that Phainon had already observed enough homoerotic moments that it would be foolish to downplay anything. His shoulders were tense.

“I’m not saying this in a threatening way,” Phainon whispered awkwardly, rubbing his neck, “I just think he likes you back. Maybe you could, I don’t know, make a move?”

Ratio’s eyebrows furrowed in distaste. “Do you often insert yourself into private matters?”

“Honestly, no, but this trip has been fuelled by so much romantic tension I think it’s polluting the air.” In order to appeal to his emotions, Phainon twisted his face into the dreaded puppy

eyes. His words were tinged with a sad, pathetic hint of a whine. “*Please.* I’m so tired of being the third wheel.”

Ratio’s eyes twitched dangerously, and the next moment Phainon was looking at that marble bust, but the doctor’s embarrassed discomfort was clear despite that barrier, arms crossed at his chest and shoulders hunched in.

“Y—You!” Ratio snapped, then hushed his voice into a deadly hiss. “It does not matter what *I* feel; I refuse to put him under any pressure! I would hate to act like those dreadful people from his past—”

Ratio released a harsh breath, shoulders rising only to fall like the snap of a guillotine; Phainon honed into the Implications and the drama like a honing missile — or, should he say, like the Lance of Fury. Ok, ok, ok. It seemed that Ratio would rather die than make the first move. (Mood, as the youth said.) Obviously, that meant that Phainon should pressure Aventurine instead, and he felt little guilt over it as he knew what had to be done.

“My apologies, I won’t bring this up again,” Phainon earnestly lied, mentally adding in a *not with you, anyway,* “I suppose that I’m too much of a romantic, but that was hardly polite… I pushed too much, didn’t I? I'm sorry.”

"Stop your unnecessary apologies." Ratio sighed deeply through that plaster bust. “I expect you to keep to your word, Phainon. Now move along; the next area is sure not to disappoint.”

Phainon let himself be ushered into the hallway by a disappointed Ratio, now feeling mildly guilty.

The Eternal DEEZ NUTS

(group chat with: Stelle, Dan Heng, Phainon)

Phainon: Hello friends, is anyone here knowledgeable about the movie preferences of their astral companions?

Stelle: ??? why do u say it so weirdly. Just say what u mean bruh im not gonna report u for snooping on aventurines or Dr. Ratio’s movie preferences

Stelle: wait yall had movies??????

Dan Heng: Yes

Dan Heng: The most popular genres seem to be comedy and tragedy

Dan Heng: Also, Stelle once mentioned that Aventurine enjoys bad horror movies

Phainon: Thank you so much!! Muahaha

Phainon: Hahaha didn’t know where that came from! Farewell!

***Phainon** has gone offline*

Stelle: wait so we never got invited to go to the movies during our several month stay there??????

Dan Heng: They were likely more focused on the impending destruction of their world as they knew it, Stelle

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Phainon had to carefully keep the grin off his face as the three of them finally emerged from the gift shop. If it were his regular, sunny grin that he'd carefully curated over his years, he wouldn't care. Unfortunately, ever since that stint of going absolutely maniacal with rage, he had found it harder to keep such chaotic energy to himself. The beginning of a proper plan was taking place, not that it was particularly complex. In fact, it was just the standard move of watching a horror movie with your crush, acting big and strong and then comforting your crush. Now this move only had a chance of working if: you were not squeamish *and* if your crush was squeamish. Yes, Phainon had tried it out with Mydei. No, it did not work as well as he hoped. Mind you, even Phainon of cycle #1149803 knew it was a stupid plan, yet persisted anyway.

His very awkward, very stilted invitation to Mydei about watching the newest horror movie, Scary Film 3, together was overheard by Hyacine and Castorice, and Phainon would hate to exclude them, especially considering how hopeful the two were. Alas, nobody but Little Ica enjoyed the movie, and that was a dubious statement to make considering Mydei had given him a handmade cookie and tenderly handfed him with a smile lit up from the gratuitous blood shed on screen. If *he* were Little Ica, he'd be in an exuberant mood for a whole week. Hyacine herself hadn't enjoyed the movie due to its medical inaccuracy.

"Personally, I think that the protagonist would have passed out from blood loss or shock long before going along with that silly deal of cutting off a leg to get out of the maze." Hyacine poked at her companion's cheeks before adding, "Not to be rude, but the practical effects like the arterial blood spray and the third-degree burns were underwhelming."

Mydei was unbothered by the egregious violence and summed up his thoughts in two simple words: beyond stupid. Of course, Phainon agreed, not just because he had little self-respect and could be quite the people pleaser at times, but mostly because the plot really was beyond stupid.

During the movie, Castorice had sat in the back, to the very left on account of her deathly (sweet!) aura. Thankfully, she mentioned that she was simply happy to be included, even when they were all watching something so stupid it would burn off Anaxa's remaining hairline from sheer rage. Phainon, however, noticed that she carefully did not mention her own opinion on the movie, and he had the suspicion she also found it uninspiring, given that she brought out her secret poetry notebook only a quarter of the way in. He even spotted his and Mydei's names several times!

When questioned privately about the matter, her pale face erupted in such vivid crimson that Phainon #1149803 never brought up the subject again in fear of her kicking the bucket from all her blood flow travelling to her face in one second.

Yet again, he got lost in the copious beloved memories, which was an improvement from the not-so-wholesome torrent that also plagued him, but also just as much of a nuisance in day-to-day life when Phainon was arguably free from his… everything. *It's peace time,* he told himself until it stuck. He instinctively felt somebody looking at him, only a side glance showing that it was just the doctor.

“Hey, Prof.” Phainon greeted, plastering on a smile.

“You've been staring at these fridge magnets for seven and a half minutes now,” Ratio commented mildly, but thankfully, he was no longer mad at him for prying. Well, it was mild for him, anyway, as his resting bitch face and tone made him seem far more aggressive than he actually was. Yet again, the images of similar people burned their images into his head like how the sun's afterimage bloomed with every blink.

“And you've staring at me with absolutely no thoughts between your thick head for roughly one minute,” Ratio commented, this time less mildly but more amused.

Phainon laughed awkwardly. “My bad. I, I was just looking at these little magnets. They seem pretty popular?”

“Indeed. Fridge magnets are generally considered a timeless gift that suits both friends, foes and annoying colleagues. Especially in this star system.”

Phainon snuck another glance at the board, all of them sporting the same font that was far too bold for something so ugly. In a harmony of pure ugliness, they all screamed PIER POINT MUSEUM with the enthusiasm of the tortured souls right by the River of Souls. Looking at the differing colour schemes, Phainon scanned each of them carefully (purple and white, navy blue and gold, pure gold, mint greens and pink…); they were of good quality and likely good material, judging by the satisfying weight of each one. But, of course, there was a bigger problem.

As if Zagreus themselves had blessed him, Aventurine seemed to sniff out whenever somebody was in need of money.

“It's on me,” Aventurine sang out with the usual levity, plucking the magnet Phainon was holding with such grace that Phainon did not feel even an iota of annoyance. Somehow, he picked the one that Phainon had been looking at. So flummoxed by that strange bout of luck, he protested far too late, and Aventurine was already running off into the counter. Ratio watched with something like pity, perhaps, as if he had been the unwilling participant of a reverse-scheme many times before.

After grabbing some more food that Ratio deemed a 'nutritional wasteland' and Aventurine a 'little bite of unholy delight', they stopped before the most colourful, swanky clothes shop he had *ever* seen. He gasped in delight — would they have orange pants?! He very much needed them after Aglaea burned them with all the Chrysos Heirs as witnesses. Aventurine winked at him when he turned around with the sheer chaotic energy of a hyperactive toddler. Ratio closed his eyes, looking upward, as if seeking advice from the cosmos itself or trying to look for his ever elusive patience.

“Is *this* where you got that pinnacle of fashion?” Phainon demanded eagerly, pointing at the dapper, fluorescent pink birds with strangely long legs.

"Sure is~" he sang out, grabbing the sleeve and pushing the hero of Amphoreus with far greater power than expected of such a slight figure. Impressed, Phainon let himself be herded like livestock to the fancy, bright *boutique.* (Was there a difference between that and a regular shop? Hm, something to consider later.)

"Absolutely not," Ratio retorted, not even bothering to open his eyes to witness the foolish shenanigans the two had gotten themselves involved in.

Phainon gave the absurdly bright tropical shirt a mourning look; Aventurine refused to give up.

"Come *on,* doc! It'll be fun!" Aventurine crowed like the nuisance he was. "You will match with us."

After a beat of silence, he sighed deeply in defeat and fled, shooting the Kremnoan hand signal for *attack* towards the warrior. Phainon warmed his expression in idle curiosity and showed off the silent wonder that had been tailing him throughout his entire journey. Whilst this tactic may not have worked on Anaxa well, it was the perfect bait for a professor like Dr. Ratio, whose sole goal in life was to disseminate the world's knowledge onto the foolish and dull. Or something. This was all Aventurine's plan.

"The birds in my homeland are quite dull in comparison to these flamingos." Phainon's voice tripped up on such an unfamiliar, albeit fun, word. "Your friend said something about its colour being a product of its environment…?"

As if a sleeper agent's codeword had been activated, Ratio's golden eyes snapped open, and Phainon was quite happily held captive in a lecture on how that bird's diet influenced their brilliant pink feathers. Ratio even showed some pictures of them, and Phainon was entranced by their absurdly long legs— he initially thought the dapper patterns had over-emphasised their scaly legs. The professor then showed a devastatingly endearing photo of a baby flamingo.

During that exchange, Aventurine had successfully brought all three shirts and lurked behind Ratio, waiting for the right moment to pounce. Even Phainon was impressed by his silent approach. However, just as Aventurine was in arm's length, whatever radar the professor had cultivated to sniff out nearby idiocy blared, sharpened into a wonder of nature after years of accompanying a certain fool on his even more foolish escapades. He sighed deeply and pinched the bridge of his nose to ward off an incoming headache.

"What have you done now?" Ratio demanded weakly, seemingly already submitting to his fate.

In response, Aventurine ushered the gift bag into his arms with a subtle laugh, which also seemed to be the final push to win against Ratio's defences. Reluctantly, he accepted the gift.

After all of the junk food Phainon had tried out, Ratio had ordered him to try out the fruits and vegetables from the market, a scant 15-minute walk away from the boutique.

"The apples from my homeworld are better," Phainon accidentally let slip out.

Ratio sighed longingly. "Unsurprising." Phainon shot a suspicious glance at him, still unsure whether that was an admission that the scholar was, indeed, from Amphoreus. Phainon let the suspicions drop.

Soon, he noticed that their group held a slightly awkward vibe when eating together. The Chrysos Heirs would often feast with each other, sharing honey mead and something Mydei made, sometimes after a successful exhibition, sometimes after a festival, sometimes for no reason at all. Given how his two companions consciously did not look at each other whilst eating or put far too much thought into their looks while eating, Phainon had his suspicions that they did not eat together often. If their relationship were to progress any further, they had to eat together — or eat each other, even. Heh.

Of course, there was the likelihood that it was Phainon's presence making things more awkward, which only meant that he had to give them the illusion of privacy at some point. Indeed, a fine plan. Phainon was going to get *such* a good score in matchmaking, which was a totally normal thing to yearn for. If Anaxa were to suddenly create a matchmaking course and teach it, Phainon would totally graduate with honours.

(Of course, Anaxa would never make such a thing, as it would involve too much self-reflection on his absolute failure of a love life, which was really ironic given that he was semi-involved with *the* demigod of Romance — ouch, Phainon got a bit aggressive there hahahah.

Throughout all of the cycles, there was always *something* going on between the two, but Phainon only realised it was something other than pure hatred until Cycle #169, in which he had killed the both of them together, only to witness his *teacher* kiss her with *tongue,* only to promptly explode himself straight afterwards in an attempt to take Khaslana down with him. His golden blood had stained her pure white dress. That was one *wild* cycle.)

"Heyyyy," Aventurine called out, looking as if he were ten seconds away from snapping his fingers in his eyesight to gain Phainon's attention and annoyance.

"Sorry, did you say something?"

Aventurine waved off his apology, "Where are you staying tonight? Did Stelle book you a place?"

"She did, just let me—" he brought out his phone, scrolling through the very incriminating messages Stelle had sent that evening (such as the waves of photographs lovingly rendered by March 7th's camera, all depicting Mydei and his peerless beauty.) Aventurine looked respectfully at his beauty; Ratio was admiring his peerless muscles, and Phainon angled the screen away.)

"This place." He said, not even attempting to pronounce the flowery name.

Aventurine's eyes narrowed in focus, then sneered. "Oh, ew, not on my watch." Then Aventurine flipped a coin. When it landed on tails, he gave a considering hum. Ratio called him an idiot. "Are you good with pets?"

Phainon gasped with such delight that he almost felt rejuvenated. He hastily flicked through his picture album (scrolling past albums such as: *Mydei I, Mydei II, Mydei III, Mydei IV, Mydei V.* The last had a black screen as the album picture), eventually scrolling into *Awooooo Firm!* with each photo comprised of the little gremlins Hyacine watched over.

Aventurine took his phone, scrolling past the dense images with the ruthless focus of a true businessman, or rather a fastidious judge. He handed them back with a nod, and Phainon remembered the time in which Kokopo III finally accepted his offerings of premium sand and love after years of biting him for the sole crime of existing.

"Doc, do you want to join us for a sleepover at my place?"

Ratio considered it. "Perhaps another time."

Aventurine's 'cake cats' were charming little menaces who managed to draw blood within the first five minutes. They would grow up to be very capable warriors, indeed. He gently squished the toe beans of the most violent cat, Poker, who accepted it with grace and churring happily from his affections, only to bite his hand twenty seconds later like an overly enthusiastic hole puncher. Her tail was curled with joy, lying over his hand with idle possessiveness.

"She isn't usually so… aggressive." Aventurine noted as he stood to the side, observing. Poker's siblings crowded around his ankle, nearly tripping him up several times as he gave Phainon a glass of water.

"Little cretins," the golden-haired man muttered, "I am *so* telling on you to Ratio." He snickered at their lamenting yowls, grabbing them into his arms with an overly dramatic apology for his harsh threat.

"Does Ratio come here often?"

"He comes here for the cats. They get angsty when he leaves them for too long." Aventurine replied, eyes narrowing in a silent threat to drop the subject. Phainon had a suspicion that it weren't only the cats who missed him.

"Well, thanks for inviting me over. Is there anything I can do for you?"

Aventurine waved off his offer. "No need. Anyway, the guest bedrooms are on the second floor, pick whichever one you want. You got all you need for the night? Good, good, I'll be heading up then."

With all three cats clinging onto him, Aventurine left the room. Just before leaving, he called out to him. "Goodnight, Phainon."

"Night!"

With that last word, he left. His words were delivered with a hesitance that betrayed his age, his tongue curling over the wish with noticeable unfamiliarity, especially as his voice and tone were smoother than butter and impenetrable as Lady Aglaea's countenance. Phainon had the feeling that there hadn't been many people for him to say *goodnight* to for a long, long time.

Ratio: I'm surprised you offered to let him stay the night

Aventurine: Awwwww, are you jealous?

Aventurine: Or even concerned for my safety?

Ratio: No. I'm glad

Aventurine: Oh? What for?

Ratio: Heh.

Ratio: I thought it would be nice for the three of us to visit the spa you mentioned. I'll pick you up at 9.

Aventurine: Hah, are you not going to answer my question? Ah well, I'm getting the impression that the next activity was something *you* wanted to do and decided to use Phainon and I as an excuse to indulge.

Aventurine: Not going to confirm or deny that, too?

Aventurine: Goodnight, Doc.

Ratio: Goodnight, you foolish gambler.

Phainon spent the night reminiscing and sorting out all of the things he witnessed — *nobody knows what a dromas is, but they have even stranger animals! Like a flamingo. Also, there are soooo many mass extinction events, I know that's unsurprising, but still!* — he wanted to share with his loved ones later on his notes app. In the end, it was even more descriptive than his usual notes for his debate club. The network connecting Amphoreus to the wider galaxy was still underway, knocking into unforeseen complications, and by that, he meant the whole planet initially being just lines and lines of coding was quite an annoyance due to some technical issues he currently did not understand. If it weren't for that, Phainon would have been constantly texting his friends instead of living in the present and trying to actually relax. The night dragged on, and the sun rose promptly at 5 A.M. It still felt as if the night, new in its darkness, flashed in a blink. Phainon hadn't slept, but it wasn’t as if he needed it.

Aventurine woke up at 7:30. Phainon heard the distant yowl of one of the cat cakes (it sounded like Poker, but her siblings weren't as vocal as here, so he was not entirely sure what

their battle cries sounded like) and then rushed apologies; Aventurine seemed to be a clumsy man in the morning.

The car ride to the spa — which *did* have baths, how lucky! — was nothing special, apart from maybe Aventurine occasionally resting his head on Ratio as he was still tired, only stopping when that nearly got them in a car crash. (Was the silence from Ratio whilst driving not a product of his general introverted nature, but perhaps… he was bad at driving and needed to focus?)

When Phainon asked this, Ratio only replied, "I need to focus because there are inept fools who somehow passed their driving tests on every single road."

Aventurine snickered at him.

They had split up to wander around the facility to choose what they would prefer. Before sauntering into the pedicure section, Aventurine had advised him to take the full-body massage.

However, it was obvious that Aventurine had failed to calculate one single thing: Phainon had somehow taken a page out of Mydei's ~~tits~~ book by gaining a nigh indestructible body that soaked up damage like a sponge. Now, in his quest to go *Super Saiyan* (according to Stelle. Nobody knew what she meant), this was a very good feature. But now? Not so much.

"I'm so sorry," the poor masseuse sobbed, forgetting to stop the entire vial of oil pouring down his back in her despair. It joined her tears on the floor. "There's— there's nothing I can do for you. I've never seen such tense knots *in my life!* Sir, are you okay?!"

Before he could respond, her eyes suddenly regained their light, hidden strength finally blooming within when everything was, quite frankly, *going to shit.*

"I cannot do anything for you anymore, sir." She whispered, not a trace of emotion in her tear-stained voice. "But I know someone who can. Please…excuse me."

She left the room with her head raised high, shoulders set with grim determination, the spirit of the indomitable human spirit glowing within so clearly Phainon could nearly taste the golden aura. He gave her his most approving nod, one forged in blood and strife. She nodded back, cool and collected.

"GRAMMY!" She yelled out, her call to arms rendering a shiver down his spine. The spa turned silent, every atom turning to attention now that the reinforcements, a one-grandma army was summoned. His intuition quaked; he was going to need faith, hope ~~and pixie dust~~ and his love for his friends and Mydei and Mydei's pectorals in his heart.

Grammy crept out of the shadows like the wraiths of a bygone era, or perhaps like the Black Tide itself, insurmountable and quiet as death itself.

"If you survive, young boy," Grammy croaked out, voice as ancient and worn down as the sand coating Pier Point. Her posture of steel indicated her true strength. "You may call me

Grammy afterwards. Now, prove to me that your case was worth my grandchild getting me out of the break room."

As Phainon had been raised to utilise proper respect when speaking to one's elders, he said, "Yes, Madam."

The other worker silently witnessed his trial, hands clasped in prayer. "Please, do not mind me; I have much to learn still."

Grammy cracked her gnarled knuckles, wiser and older than the Grove of Epiphany itself, and then set her tiny shoulders into a king's resting position. Behind her thick lenses, she scanned his shoulders and back, finding no blemishes apart from severe emotional scars, knots hard enough to crack steel and the possibility of future scoliosis if she didn't fix his back right then and there.

"Please be gentle," Phainon begged quietly, dread writhing within him; not even Nanook or that bitch Lygus had ever scared him right down to the core of his heart, locked behind layers and layers of good humour, trauma, deflection, people pleasing, trauma, wrath and hope.

Grammy narrowed her hazy brown eyes at him. "If you wanted *gentle,*" she spat out, "you should've gone to your *boyfriend,* bitch boy."

With those final words, Phainon closed his eyes and dreamt of Aedes Elysiae. Her hands found his weak spots and relentlessly beat them up. Wheat fields, the perfectly blue sky, his Ma's cooking, smoke rising from the hearth. Grammy held his shoulders down and went to town. He felt nothing but the agony of settled stress being punted out by some little old woman's hands. His torso seized about, a dying fish placed on that butcher's table.

"You cannot run away from here, nor can you continue to run away from the present." She hissed out. "You've achieved it all, haven't you? Your world is rescued by the Nameless Hero, the Deliver, the Dawn-Denied Khaslana. You are finally *free.* But you don't know what to do with yourself now that the future has finally been unlocked."

She pressed her palms into his shoulder blades and *pushed,* pressure exiting with a dying whimper. "Admit it: that small part of yourself wishes you could go back to those recurrent cycles — you knew exactly what would await. By having no future, you did not have to *grow,* grow past your title of Deliverer and the young boy nestled deep within. You could see your home again, even if only for a nostalgic-dimmed heartbeat. You didn't have to face yourself and your friends, who will grow out of the need to keep you close, who will have to *decide* whether they want you in your life. You didn't have to take the true, meaningful steps into fully accepting *his* love."

Trussed up like a damn turkey, Phainon could only take the verbal slaughtering.

"Even now, you look into the mirror and find yourself *lacking.* But I promise you, young boy, you will find the strength to grow beyond the shadow of those endless cycles."

She struck down on his tenth thoracic vertebra.

It cracked wetly, like Mydei #2's sole weak point when Phainon missed the sweet spot at first and had to spend the next few minutes hacking and cleaving at his lover's poor, abused spine as he couldn't see through the tears. *Sorry, Cycle 2's Mydei*, he thought grimly, *I now truly understand your agony. May we meet again where the West Wind blows—*

She struck down again, and something gave way.

His body seized up, ghosts and vague impressions of the coreflames he'd once accumulated over 33 million epochs *blazing.* His unfamiliar vessel surged with inhuman power, gold scars melting rivers through charred limbs, chest burning burning *burning—*

“Get that ratty thing *off* my operating table,” she snarled, and Khaslana nearly ripped the remaining wing off in his haste to 'yeet' it off the table.

"Sorry, Ma'am." He gasped out, wing futilely fluttering as he was pinned down.

When Aventurine had said full-body massage, he *meant* it. Grammy probably scraped a whole layer of dead akin off his body by the end of it during her hellish ministrations.

Khaslana heaved a mighty sob that shocked the still water surrounding his heart; he thought of his loved ones and their ghosts that haunted him even when they gave him their blessings.

"But— but how can I move one, I'm so sick—so sick of feeling like I'm stuck rolling up a boulder up an impossible mountain where the only thing I'm in control of is how quickly I push it up."

She nodded sagely, her massaging now softer as the past shed like a snake's scales. "You may find others during your journey, such as the itsy bitsy spider and Kate Bush."

"W—Who?"

"Never mind, love. You have friends to rely on. Your burden is nigh incomprehensible, but the love stayed, no? Well, to be frank, that burden is incomprehensible to *you* right now, as you've never had the time nor the energy to truly process your overwhelming grief. Remember this, young boy, your friends *want* you to share your feelings, especially when they are messy or disgusting. Stop holding it in, or I will personally shatter your tenth thoracic vertebra. After all, you would do the same thing for yourself, no?"

Phainon sniffled. "Do you have any more sage advice, Grammy?"

"Your wish is shit. Live for yourself from now on. Go wear those ugly ass clothes and do karaoke or some shit with your newest friends."

The sun, weakened and battered, finally started to rise, not with agony or rage, but the quiet, burgeoning hope of a new beginning, a true dawn rising, not just for Amphoreus, but for him as well.

"Thank you," he whispered, "but how do you know all of this…?"

She passed him a towel. "That doesn't matter — go to the baths."

Back in his mortal form and lighter than a feather, Phainon floated to the bathhouse, untethered by worldly desires (apart from his lover's pectorals, of course, as a treat) and strife. His skin was smoother than a baby's, and he felt every atom of air brushing against new skin. He shivered and continued his journey onwards.

By a stroke of fortune, he found his two companions bathing in the same spot, Aventurine sinking down until only his face was visible and Ratio with his entire upper torso shown. He noted that the scholar had impressive pectorals and biceps for such a nerd. Aventurine also thought the same, as his eyes were glued onto his bust. Despite being the second-most paranoid, constantly aware-of-their-surroundings blond Phainon had ever personally met, Aventurine did not notice him at all, far too engrossed by the heaving badonkadonks in front of him until Phainon entered the baths, finding them nicely warm.

Ratio took in the bruises developing around his torso and the blood that dribbled out of his mouth, already crusting over.

"Did you happen to get into a fight with your masseuse?" Ratio questioned, already thinking of the salves Phainon might need. He paid no attention to the thirsty maniac beside him. Fondly, he thought of all those times he took Mydei out to the baths (and *'baths'*), sometimes even twice a day if they were both free enough. He let that warmth soak his bones, then refocused.

"Yeah. Grammy got me good."

At that name, Aventurine finally twitched back into sentience. "Grammy's still here? Her descendants have been trying to get her to retire for, like, a century. Oh, damn, I can see that her … loving touch has left its impact."

"Have you ever gone head to head with Grammy?" Phainon ignored Ratio's incredulous look as he tried to work out whatever the fuck was going on.

"Yeah. She's the reason why I didn't go insane, like, fifteen years ago and still have a modicum of human decency, y'know?"

For a pure, golden minute, Phainon melted into the baths. They weren't nearly as opulent or had as many oils as the Hero's Baths in Okhema, but they were pretty good.

Phainon nodded thoughtfully to himself. "I think I might propose to Mydei."

Ratio's brows furrowed further; Aventurine '*ooooh*'ed and gestured for him to keep going. After muttering about fools and idiots, Ratio escaped to the colder baths and held his head underneath the water, either testing out his lung capacity or drowning out their voices.

"It's like — I love him with all my heart, I really do, but I've never said *anything* about the true depths of my love*,* never even made the first move *once* over the course of 33550336 cycles—"

Here, Aventurine's ever-present smile wavered in confusion.

"He usually comes up to me, challenges me to a duel, and if I lose, he tells me that we're now romantic partners and if I refuse, I'll have to kill him in another duel. If I win the first time, he challenges me until he wins, but by then he moves to underhanded tactics like flexing his tits when he knows I really love them when we wrestle—"

Ratio was definitely trying to drown himself now, judging by the smothered screaming.

"— but I've never told him that I love him. Fucked up, isn't it? I can't say the words to him, but to you guys, I can somehow say it! But— but how can I propose to him when I've killed him 33550336 times over through his singular weak spot that he always trusts me with?!"

Aventurine's smile crumpled into mild despair. His weak, guttural cry of *buddy, I think you need to go back to Grammy* was duly noted, but Phainon carried on.

"But I've already told him about that, and he forgave me, but how can *I* forgive myself— oh, yes, Grammy told me what to do! I must move on. I cannot rewrite our past, but we can make love AND new memories that aren't shadowed by our cruel fates!"

He stood up, arms splayed in passion. "Oh, when I get back, I will cook him breakfast and ardently profess my love for him and desire to grow as a person and show him the depths of my love and admiration for his peerless body *every single day.* Until death or that fucker Nanook and his loser Emanators try to pull me away from his loving arms!"

So lost in his passionate speech that would give his speech at the Flamechase debate a run for its money, he only realised that Aventurine fled to take refuge in Ratio's loving bosom afterwards. Phainon smiled, knowing that his general state of mental unwellbeing had pushed them closer. Ah, young love truly was a sight to behold!

Chapter End Notes

Also its up to you whether ratio is naturally a bad driver who needs to put in his whole pussy into that ardurous task, or if the other drivers are the problem lol. Listened to coronal radiance (phainons Depression Era ost) during the massage.

Also the spider and kate bush thing — look here:

https://www.tumblr.com/birdsareblooming/775831186235916288/holy-shit-is-that-kate-bush

Pls don't try any of the massage techniques discussed here, I know your back's already in bad enough shape.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

> Ok so i had a self imposed deadline of finishing this fic before 3.5 came out and. well. you see that chapter increase? yeah its staring at me in mockery. I got suckered into, yet again, collecting the current nation's oculi (genshin) before the next nation dropped so my ravenous need to collect them fully distracted me for a while. Hope yall enjoy and if i dont get hysilens i may disappear off the planet. so. Happy reading

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 3

Whenever Khaslana went through the next cycle with most of his morals and sanity strained and holding on by a thread, he would lay out the bare truth of his quest. Yes, he was going to take your coreflame; yes, he knows that you will never let it go without death; yes, he has done this *x* number of times; yes, he has *12x* coreflames burning him from the inside out. No, he will not stop. No, he will not stop. No, he will not stop. (Yes, it hurt.)

This has perhaps led to an unfortunate habit: forgetting that his words, well-intentioned or not, would not disappear with death nor the next eternal recurrence.

In the changing rooms, he went to his knees.

"I am *so* sorry for the, uh," he struggled to remember the term he'd heard Stelle mention several times, "trauma dumping."

Both of them shared a look without saying anything at first, showing off the depth of a bond forged in fire and suffering.

"Go see a shrink." Was the advice Ratio gave before escaping into the showers.

Aventurine waved him off, "I see why Grammy's treatment would have that effect. It's no big deal."

"Have you ever gone back to her?"

"She said only to come back when I had a boyfriend as that would 'open up a whole different can of worms' apparently."

"Damn."

Phainon's master plan was going wonderfully, and if he were a bird, he'd practically be preening. Alas, confined to a human body and the expectations that came along with it, Phainon's smile stayed politely joyous until the cinema went black. Immediately, it twisted into a smile more suited for a fae waiting for disaster to strike.

He chose to sit two rows behind them, far enough to give the foretold illusion of privacy, but close enough to snoop. Ever since the movie started, Phainon ceased breathing for minimised presence.

As Stelle had informed Dan Heng, who had informed him, Aventurine was, indeed, unaffected by the gory slasher movie. Phainon squinted — indeed, his posture was actually even more relaxed than any other time during the vacation, potentially due to the morning's spa, but likely because he'd convinced Ratio to take his hand. Phainon nearly yelled from joy when Ratio accepted. Aventurine even took his gloves off for maximum skin contact — that man had *game.* It could have even been a rather obvious metaphor for something cooking between them (trust and vulnerability), but it was also flirty.

Phainon was impressed, mostly of himself for cooking up such a plan that minimised suffering. Even though Ratio tensed at nearly every jumpscare and blood-curdling scream, especially when he anticipated it, he didn't seem too scared. Hopefully.

But that was what the hero in shining armour, Aventurine himself, was for! At first, it was the hand holding, and then the blond's tactics escalated, soon leaning towards his crush during the more thrilling parts to perhaps create a very subtle physical barrier between them, and then Ratio leaned more to the left as the movie progressed. Aventurine's head was nearly on that man's shoulder! Phainon really was going to get a passing grade in matchmaking if things continued!!

As the main character dealt with the ethical dilemma of either cutting off the child's or the old man's legs to save their own lives, Phainon came to several epiphanies. (The first being that this particular movie's plot was also disappointingly simple, and the special effects also left a lot to be desired — such underwhelming arterial blood spray!)

Secondly, when Phainon the Dumbass of Cycle ??? invited Mydei to the movies, he shouldn't have placed himself in the role of the hero at all! No, what Phainon of Cycle *x* should have been doing was playing the damsel! In extreme and implausible distress! *He* should have been leeching off of Mydei’s good graces by burrowing his face into that tattooed, delicious neck of his instead of even entertaining the silly, reckless plan of Mydei feeling even a shiver of adrenaline watching such a C-tier movie!

With a green face, he was miserably glad that his pawns had managed to score a good movie date.

"If you ever get too scared," he heard the low, soothing murmur of Aventurine’s voice, nigh indecipherable from the background wailing, "just look at me."

"Idiot." Ratio retorted, his face glowing red despite the awful lighting.

What had Phainon done? He was suffering from success. He was so damn envious he was going to throw up. Or even explode and take the whole planet down with him.

The climax of the film was steadily approaching. It was very obvious that the protagonist's homoerotic best friend was the villain mentally and psychologically torturing him behind an ugly mask.

Left in the back seats and being forced to watch as two maybe-lovers watched the other more than the movie made Phainon feel such a pang of sympathy for the lovely Castorice his stomach turned.

And then his brain, fully against both his will and expectations, began to connect the motherfucking dots. The third revelation held him hostage.

Her poetry book. His and Mydei's names, over and over again. The chimerasonas that always held *juuuuust* a bit too much resemblance to the Chrysos Heirs. Castorice was the one who was always, always overcome with infectious joy when news broke out about his and Mydei's updated relationship. Her attempts at matchmaking and peacemaking only made sense at that very moment, light years away from Amphoreus. Her three separate social media accounts, with the most secretive holding the most followers.

One time, they even wrote real person fanfiction together. It was Castorice who held the trigger and the pen and the lustrous prose together, deftly creating a mournful, yearning and corrosive epic of the Heretic and the Goldweaver. Phainon, out of drunken annoyance that he'd been held back a full decade from graduating; Castorice writing from the quiet joy of it.

The antagonist ripped off their ugly skull mask, revealing the bitch ass best friend's face underneath.

Phainon gasped in despair. "Oh Titans above!" He shouted.

GoldenHeretic was *not* Castorice's first rodeo into writing Chrysos Heir RPF.

In tandem with the protagonist, he despaired, "Oh, *why*, cruel world."

Somehow, over the course of 33 million epochs, he had never realised one of his best friends had been *fujoshi-ing out* (another Stelle Special) over him and Mydei. How had he been so damn *blind?*

In front of him, the hazy, romantic bubble between the destined couple broke.

"… Did he really not get that twist within the first five minutes?" Aventurine whispered, ears unnervingly close to the doctor's ear, who reflexively shivered.

"I believe he's going through a crisis unrelated to the movie." Ratio turned away first. Then, he nudged his head gingerly onto Aventurine's soft hair, who stayed in place.

Aventurine smelled the faint apple scent of his doctor's shampoo, face brightening like a supernova, but his shoulders and neck as steady as time itself. *Oh, Gaithra Triclops, thank*

the heavens for the dim lighting. His hands flexed, curling over Ratio's just a tad harder. Still, neither of them pulled away for the duration of the movie.

Ratio did not flinch for the rest of the movie, even through the vengeance-fuelled montage of the protagonist beating their ex-situationship to death with a shovel.

Once the light finally dawned upon them again, it was clear that Phainon had gone through a most arduous moment of realisation, burdened by a most grim knowledge. Phainon ate the popped corn with morose disbelief. Aventurine reluctantly pulled away from his situationship before either of them had to face their unplatonic reactions..

"I think my friend has been writing poetry about me and Mydeimos since the very first cycle *and I never realised.* I'm a complete fool."

Ratio nodded in solemn agreement whilst Aventurine eyed the street for places to flee. (Ugh, maybe he shouldn't have invited him over to his actual apartment — he should've sent him to the summer house one two light centuries away.)

"How did I not notice?" Phainon whispered, eyes vacant.

Ratio glanced down at his watch, noting that he had a meeting in an hour. "By your reaction, it seems your friend's hobby was not particularly discreet. It's almost impressive that you missed being her muse for over 33 million lifetimes."

Phainon thought back to that dreadful cycle wherein he could no longer look his Professor in the eyes. Out of morbid curiosity, he asked, "Have you ever been…?" His sentence wandered off as his sanity flew back into him — there wasn't a good way to ask *hey have you had raunchy smut written about you,* nor was there any good reason why Phainon blurted it out. Damn, Phainon pre-massage would still have some semblance of social anxiety.

"One of my philosophy students accidentally sent in a 70,000 one-shot of myself in an ABO setting instead of their final assignment." His gaze went distant. "I ended up pulling an all-nighter to read it all. It was a most entertaining work of fiction and held fascinating insights into the problems of modern healthcare, with pre-existing concerns of bodily autonomy brought into another light due to the setting. Alas, she discontinued the series for 'personal reasons', and I believe it was because of that incident."

Phainon gaped — did the cosmos also have that accursed fictional trope?!

"… What is this 'ayy-bee-oh'?"

"You sweet summer child…" Phainon mourned.

They walked around the streets in only mildly awkward silence, a big step up from all of Phainon's other moments in creating an awkward atmosphere. His embarrassed state was soon drawn by a familiar, elusive and empty smile. In one of the many, many candy stores in

Pier Point (allegedly it was an 'open secret' that some were just money laundering schemes) he saw a photo of Aventurine and his mildly smug, polite smile-smirk on display.

When he pointed it out, Aventurine laughed, face smoothing into the same smirk on display. "This store had a rather unique… fad that went viral a couple of years ago. I simply completed it and, ever since, my face has been on the wall of fame." For a moment, his smile transformed into a more mischievous grin that crinkled the corners of his eyes. His teeth flashed; Phainon felt a smidge of dread arise. "Wanna bring back some for your friends?"

Well, Tribbie and the others probably would like to try out some candy, especially Castorice and Mydei, who both had a sweet tooth one would usually find in a toddler.

And, well, his gifts *were* a bit underwhelming. He'd only brought those swanky fridge magnets, postcards, some snacks, clothes, jewellery (from both higher-end places and some from random stalls that were probably also money laundering schemes — but as Aventurine told him beforehand, they *were* really pretty. There were some thicker gold bracelets that would look *great* on Mydei, but then again, everything looked good on him—) and, finally, a really ugly cat statue for Anaxagorous or for Aglaea, depending on who would hate-love it more — yikes. Thinking about the list made him realise that he was definitely in debt to Aventurine. He didn't expect to become a sugar baby *again.*

"Sure!" Phainon managed to squeak out, still unsure whether Aventurine was lying when he said all those gifts were on him.

The lone salesperson perked up, not necessarily at the sight of new people to scam, but more so at the sight of *the* Aventurine Stoneheart. His portrait loomed over her like a herald of destruction wrapped in a glossy veneer, shiny eyes and shiny teeth sparkling.

"Are you here for a rematch?" She asked with a palpable reverence to the blond man beside him, the other two rendered unimportant.

Aventurine laughed smoothly and shook his head. "Ah, no, this is for my friend to try out." He gestured to Phainon; she looked at him as if he were a lamb ripe for the slaughter, pity in her eyes mixed with insatiable thirst for violence.

Once they made the purchase (she slipped to the back rooms and handed it off as discreetly as she could), Aventurine assured him, "There's no need for that look, mighty hero — besides, you'll be trying it out at my place."

Under the excuse of checking up on the 'little snack miscreants', Ratio finally allowed himself to be kidnapped for a proper sleepover. Phainon was amused to note that Aventurine already knew what the excuse was going to be, *and* that neither of the adult men before him had certainly ever had a sleepover before, much less with each other. That meant it was up to Phainon to act as the social lubricant of the night, of course, by using all of his previous experience to set up a sleepover that wouldn't end in disaster for their romantic prospects.

One thing that he hadn't accounted for was his non-existent, downright hostile baking skills. After the first time, even Hyacine barred him from entering her kitchen, and Little Ica would

doot-doot with such forlorn misery whenever Phainon stepped a foot inside, even for a mere glass of water.

"Why didn't you preheat the oven?" He'd never heard Ratio so pissed before; now he fully understood why Stelle ran away from him in the train station. Aventurine, the lucky man on the sidelines, watched with mischievous glee. "Have you ever preheated an oven before? Phainon, *answer me.*"

"Um." Phainon had to use all of his charisma currently available to avert the upcoming execution. May Castorice save him. "I-I've never preheated the oven."

At the resounding, loud silence, Phainon rushed to explain himself, "Honestly, I never thought people actually did that. Like putting in fabric softener into the laundry machine."

Ratio summoned chalk out of thin air, and Aventurine snickered with great amusement, big bug eyes taking in the show. "Minus points — *get out of my kitchen*."

With no more time left to squander, Phainon prostrated himself on the floor and did what he did best: talk, talk and *talk.*

"Have mercy, please! It's always been my beloved making meals for our friends and I to share and I thought to surprise him with a recipe from beyond the skies—"

"Cease your crocodile tears and rise." Ratio gave him a look that he'd seen on his old professor many times before, usually right before he sentenced Phainon to another year of failing his graduation, a look encompassed with disappointment and the desire to actually push their students beyond their limits. Man. He really should have listened to those instructions.

Ratio pulled up the recipe on his phone. "Alright then. We're starting with browning the butter."

Phainon squinted, damn well knowing that wasn't in the recipe.

"A *beginner* ought to follow the recipe to the letter," Ratio snapped.

"Browning butter is a technique used by many bakers to give their products a richer, nuttier flavour that enhances everything that needs butter, such as cookies and sauces. It is a result of the maillard reaction, which…"

Phainon focused on his words and the saucepan in front of him with the strained focus that carried him throughout his time in Amphoreus. The butter had already melted, the water slowly evaporating, and then the temperature of the milk solids began to increase drastically. Soon, the butter began to brown, as the name suggested, releasing a nutty aroma through the room. Was the temperature too high??

Ratio nodded in approval beside him, and the tremor in Phainon's hands finally receded.

"Why are you relaxing? We still have to combine the other ingredients, now get to it!"

"Yes, chef." Phainon received a swat on the arm for his response.

Phainon took another bite of the chocolate chip cookies that were so good even Idrilla THEMSELVES would weep in envy at their beauty. "Thank you," he croaked out, "is this the true dawn denied from my people.?

"How needlessly dramatic — it's just a cookie."

"No, Doc, they really are that good. I think Idrilla THEMSELVES must have blessed you and the cookies."

Ratio rolled his eyes, calling Aventurine a fool (affectionate) before ignoring everyone in the room to focus on the cat snack cat pet beings (?), stroking Poker's squishy case (torso??) until she all but melted into a little puddle of feline contentment. Phainon was betrayed by the sight — what did Ratio have that made *all* of the cats like him? Was it because Phainon had too much puppy energy?? Was Phainon just not good enough for those rascals???

Stewing in jealousy, he took another cookie, reclining back on the couch, which had a boxier look to it than anything out of Amphoreus, but it was so sinfully comfortable he could probably fall asleep on it.

"Have you guys ever had a sleepover before?" Phainon checked, and both confirmed they hadn't, which all lined up with his expectations. "Alright then. We will be building a blanket fort, then — if I allow both of you to go without this experience, I will have failed in my duty in being Okhema's Number One Blanket Fort Builder. Aventurine, do you have any extra blankets you could give out?"

"Sure?" Aventurine said, something in his voice suggesting he'd never constructed one before.

(Unbidden, he remembered that he was always in second place in that particular contest growing up — it was always more popular in Aedes Elysiae, where he was always beaten by Pito, the hunter's child.)

Through Phainon's expertise and Ratio's general knowledge, the fort went along swimmingly, especially as the blond brought some wine along with him. It was sharper and more bitter than the usual ceremonial wines Mydei, and by extension Phainon, drank. It wasn't bad at all.

And then someone knocked on the overly grandiose doors.

"Finally," Ratio muttered, taking all three cats into his arms as he left. The door was hefted open, and Phainon could just about make out some manic cackling that he was distinctly familiar with after a year and a weird lifetime spent listening to that hyena-esque sound.

Stelle rounded the corner with a demonic grin splitting her face in half as if she were a particularly uninspired edgy internet trend, her little raccoon hands filled with a charming

purple rabbit plushie (well, rabbit inspired? It was quite stretched out and patchy) and Poker in the other, holding her up like a plate.

"It's Britney, bitch." Stelle cackled. Not even the judgmental silence coming from all directions was enough to pull down her spirits. "Now let's get this party started!"

"That is the ugliest thing I've ever seen," Aventurine said, idly pointing at the plushie. Phainon gasped at him, betrayed by who he thought was his fashionista brother-in-arms.

"Eh, it's for the cats. And look! Poker's already tearing the toy apart, so that means she loves it!"

As they all huddled into the blanket fort together, Aventurine asked Ratio, "I didn't think you'd invite another person around, not that I mind, it's just… unexpected for you."

"It would be easier for me to slip away," Ratio shrugged his shoulders. Aventurine laughed as if he had told a joke.

Stalking closer to him, Stelle flexed her biceps at him, signalling she wanted a hug. As she was the first physically affectionate person he had interacted with in what felt like a century, Phainon eagerly ran up to her, wrapping his arms around her like a starving constrictor.

"Urfghh," She grumbled out, "you could kill the average person with that, bro."

And then her eyes locked onto his pristine cookie lying on the table.

"No." He warned her as if she were an unruly chimera. "That's mine — go get your own, you rabid raccoon."

Stelle meekly nodded — had her time away from the stressful environment of a perpetual doomsday mellowed her out? — and she backed away. Of course, the moment Phainon let go of her, she lunged for the baked good, which Phainon retaliated with a very gentle suplex onto the aforementioned comfortable couch. He then sat on her torso. Gently, might he remind you, even as Stelle writhed around like an angry bucket of worms beneath him, hissing and biting his arm like a raccoon — an animal introduced to him by the Nameless, notoriously known for messing around with garbage, which lent itself to becoming the animal Stelle would forever be compared to.

"That's not very honourable of you, Stelle. They'd execute you for that in Kremnos."

Stelle did not reply as she was in the midst of a most arduous quest to bite his forearm off.

Within the blanket fort, Ratio commented, "There's an entire batch still in the pan. Why must they be so foolish?"

"Perhaps it's just a sibling thing," Aventurine laughed softly, flicking an errant strand of hair out of Ratio's eyes, who thanked him by pushing his foolish gambler down to lay his head on his lap until the chaos receded. Aventurine let out a noise that could have been a smothered yelp of joy, his face flushed brightly enough that Ratio could see it creeping up his ears. He

mentally noted down the reaction with a strange, giddy satisfaction, but did not say anything else.

As anybody with at least two brain cells could gather, the night quickly delved into chaos once Stelle made them all play some bastardised version of Truth or Dare in which she got out a random name generator and whoever was picked could ask the dreaded question to anybody in the room. She also confirmed that it would be allowed to gang up on one specific person.

"Aventurine," Stelle began with a grandiose tone, intoning each and every syllable as if she were reading out a death penalty, "truth or dare?"

"Truth."

"Give me your— wait, what?"

Aventurine shrugged. "I ought to keep you on your toes every now and then."

Stelle gaped like a fish, looking in Ratio's direction with disbelief. Alas, Ratio deemed the game to be extremely foolish and had dedicated his energy to grading the poor remnants of the homework he'd given Stelle right before she set off to the Eternal Land. It was, to put it lightly, chewed up, but Phainon was uncertain what had left such strange teeth marks on only the margins of the paper but had left the actual writing mostly unaffected. The bite marks had suspiciously human teeth, but *he* wasn't going to snitch on her to a teacher.

"Alright then." Stelle soon recovered, determination lighting up her amber eyes. "Tell me your credit card number, the security code and expiry date."

Aventurine hummed in thought. "I don't know, that's quite a strange question. I'll switch to dare, then."

"Give me your credit card."

"Eh," Aventurine checked his nails, "I don't really feel like getting up, especially when one of your fur niblings is sitting on me."

The Trailblazer, other Deliverer of Amphoreus, Saviour of Amphoreus, Eating Champion in several worlds, acquiesced. "Very well. We'll go onto the next person then."

It landed on Ratio, who shot the device an aggrieved stare. "Stelle, truth or dare?" he began to order. Before she could answer, he said, "Go to bed early."

"But— but you didn't even ask!"

"Rules are made to be broken, no? Besides, this game is already an untraditional version of Truth or Dare. "

Stelle, who had only just begun to take debating lessons from Ratio, accepted her losses. "You act as if you have experience with this game, Prof Bro."

"You have truly exceeded expectations on horrible nicknames," Ratio mused, writing something in blood red ink on the paper, "as for your question: let me remind you that I spend quite a lot of time around university students, of course I've picked up a thing or two."

Stelle accepted his answer without further comment; Phainon was now picked, and he felt his matchmaking virus raise its head. Aventurine's gaze sharpened, if only for a second, as if he knew exactly what Phainon was planning to do. Deciding to take mercy on the blond, he went to his other victim.

"Ratio, truth or dare."

"Truth."

"Name a crush of yours."

Ratio's pen stopped its fluid stroke with a jarring quiver, sliding off the margins where a *5/10* lay. "How unimaginative."

Stelle gaped at his lack of subtlety. Aventurine's smile trembled around the edges before it was discreetly smoothed out, the cat in his grasp enquiring after his sudden distress with a tiny *'mreow?'* that went mostly unnoticed.

"Well, this morning I was reminiscing on my lone childhood crush as I saw their name on the news again. Perhaps it was nothing more than a great amount of respect rather than true attraction, but they hold a special place in my heart."

"Who?"

"Polka Kakamond. I always knew I wanted to grow up to be like her."

Everybody looked at Ratio. Stelle gaped even more. Did Phainon know that name from somewhere…?

"The Genius Society member primarily known for killing other members of the faction?" Aventurine asked, unsure of whether he should be glad Ratio hadn't mentioned anyone he personally knew or whether he wanted to strangle Phainon to death — an act he had a 100% success rate in. Ratio made an affirmative noise before returning to marking.

"OBJECTION!" Stelle yelled, almost bringing the fort down with her. "Phainon specified *a* crush — does that mean you have multiple ones? Furthermore, are there any *current* crushes you have?!"

"I suppose you'll have to ask me when it's your go."

In despair, she spun the name generator again, now landing on Stelle. Despite Ratio's provocations, each of them must have unanimously agreed to wave away such tender topics.

"Uhm. Phainon. Truth or dare?"

"… truth." He asked, as he did not want to risk being robbed in broad daylight (well, it was night here, but that phrase was used all the time back home as it was, well, always daytime —), nor be asked anything too strange.

"Okay. So. Imagine this scenario. You are sandwiched between Mydei and the personification of Lyg*s' death, three inches deep within Mydei and Personification two inches deep inside you. Which way are you moving?"

Even Ratio stopped marking for a second, if only to question what layer of hell he had descended upon. Aventurine momentarily wondered how she managed to censor his name out loud. Phainon croaked out, "Pardon?" And then he added, "I'm very loyal to the love of my life, Mydei, so my only answer is— wait, I just remembered — is Polka related to Lygus somehow? I swear I know that name—"

Stelle blinked rapidly as if she were manually firing the neurons in her chaotic brain manually. "Oh yeah. Lyg*s set up defences specifically against Polka during his fuckass experiments so she wouldn't immediately annihilate him in two seconds flat." She considered for another moment, "You know what, Ratio? I get your childhood crush now, what a *queen.*"

The wheel spun once more, finally landing on Aventurine, who was beginning to think the odds were impressively stacked against him, given his usual luck in luck-based events.

In vengeance, he asked Phainon, "Truth or dare, friend?"

"Dare," Phainon automatically replied to avoid the last incident, only to automatically regret it when Aventurine's smile stretched with malice.

"Eat the candy."

Phainon exited the blanket fort, finding it soon after. He looked at the piece he picked up with suspicion. It looked wholly unnatural, a mini sphere of abyssal inkiness and shards of sugar (?) crackling throughout the strange man-made invention. It looked a bit like concrete and glass, now that he finally took a good look at it. He ate it—

He stumbled down onto the floor. If he could scream through the suffocating, painful bitterness of life, he'd beg for mercy from an unnamed entity, or perhaps he'd call out for his loved ones, if only to wish them a good life before he passed away. His limbs flailed around in instinctual pain as if to ward off evil, the bitterness of the candy somehow hijacking all of his nerves.

"Spit it out." Ratio demanded, but Phainon was many things, but *not* a quitter. "Spit it out!"

When Ratio made a move to physically exorcise the sweet as if he were some clueless dog that ate chocolate, Phainon started to crunch on it, his teeth twinging for a second, releasing both a sound reserved for somebody's skull getting caved in by a massive golden claymore and even more putrid bitterness. His fight or flight (alternate version) must have activated, for when he looked down at his shivering body, through a veil of tears, the golden limbs of his alternate form glowed.

He sniffled, then closed his eyes, swearing that he could hear Thanatos' whispers from beyond the Sea of Souls. "I don't think anything has come so close to killing me for good as that awful concoction. The fury of innumerable Coreflames has consumed me."

Stelle nabbed one of the candy's fragments and, without any hesitation whatsoever, ate it, tastebuds dying in the process.

Aventurine looked at them with smug incredulity, but he supposed that he had a pretty good advantage in those extreme eating contests two years ago, considering his stomach of steel (now spoiled by better eating habits gently forced upon him by Ratio) and his dead-inside state back then. Ratio looked at the foolish scene in front of him with raised blood pressure and dismay, then turned around to take refuge in the fort.

Only a few minutes later, the rest of them arrived, Stelle carrying Phainon, now reverted into his usual form, on her back.

"One more round," he wheezed out.

Yet again, the phone picked Aventurine. He nudged Ratio's ribs with his clothed feet, laughing when both the doctor and the cat lying on his head looked at him with a similar grumpiness. He nudged him again, knowing that Ratio had already guessed that he was the next victim.

"Dare," Ratio said, elegantly swatting Aventurine's foot away as if he were an oversized blond fly. Poker swished her tail in interest, hopping down to also fight off Aventurine's foot. (Stelle's gift was destroyed within five minutes. The cat clearly had the spirit of a warrior within; Phainon should introduce her to Mydei.)

"You menace!" Aventurine declared with fake betrayal, somehow wrangling the pastry puff into his arms with an exceptional sneak attack, where she settled down into a less aggressive state. "Alright, Ratio, you're heading out to Karaoke Night tomorrow with us then! And you're not allowed to half-ass anything!"

"As if I would ever do such a thing." Ratio huffed with exaggerated annoyance, "I'm surprised you didn't mention your other plans."

"The clubbing? Eh, you'd prefer 30 minutes of karaoke than 1 minute of clubbing."

Stelle coughed out something that sounded suspiciously like 'softie', but the pair were already lost in their own world, looking at each other with such romantic tension that Phainon was feeling his Mydei Deprivation hit hard.

The wheel picker glowed ominously and with great evil as Stelle's finger hovered over it; he clasped his hand over hers and shook his head. As the man who opened up Zagreus' Box with his impulsive questioning, Phainon decided it was finally time to stop, preferably on a higher note. He sweetened the deal by handing her another cookie.

It was some dark hour before sunrise that Phainon, rising from a disturbed rest, paced around his room like a cornered boar before conceding to his desire to wander around the hallways on quiet feet and even quieter breaths, feeling like one of the spooky apparitions of the Grove. However, it would be rude to appraise his host's furniture and interior decoration in the dead of night, so he went to the kitchen — perhaps some water would cool the lingering, queasy panic that settled into his bones.

It was there he met Aventurine, or rather, he heard him just before Phainon had entered the kitchen, and he could tell the blond had also heard his arrival for his breath spiked, if only once. Phainon knocked on the door, as quietly as Thanatos themselves, to not disturb the night's hushed veil.

"Come in," Aventurine answered, voice clear and as confident as it usually was.

Phainon, upon entering the room, almost expected that Aventurine's eyes would glow, impressively flashy as they were, but there was only the vague impression of shadows and light in the room rather than any colour. He turned the light on, then Aventurine squinted at the sudden light and he quickly apologised.

"No problem," Aventurine said, and he looked a bit less like the flashy peacock he was often called and a bit more like a lost soul wandering about, unsure of where to go next. The dim lighting didn't do his rather pallid features any favours and his perpetual smile was faint, washing out his unstyled golden hair as well. Of course, it was only natural that anyone would look less than perfect in their homes during the night, but it only just occurred to him how much of Aventurine was built on golden perfection.

"You want some water?"

"Sure. Thank you," Phainon replied, momentarily struck from his thoughts. "…Couldn't sleep?"

Aventurine's eyes were even more lifeless than usual, more akin to a black hole than something of organic matter and his hands trembled minutely as he passed the glass to him, only visible through the water rippling chaotically. He retreated into himself quickly, gathering his arms beside him, but Phainon had noticed that his fingernails were bitten raw, nearly to the skin — maybe that was why he wore gloves all the time.

"You seem," Phainon hesitated, "troubled."

Aventurine only shot him a vaguely amused look, rendered somewhat mocking by the emptiness in his eyes, as if he had long since picked up on Phainon's own restlessness. "No more than you," he murmured at nothing, eyes slipping away into the darker corners. "Besides, they're only errant thoughts, nothing much to care about."

"Oh, I understand," Phainon replied as he had no idea how to even begin to crack open the source of a new friend's troubles. "But you can tell me about it. If you want, that is."

Aventurine pushed his voice into something resembling levity. "Truly? Even if they're about you?"

"Then especially so," Phainon immediately stated, heart jumping — what had he even done? Ughh, one of his maybe-friends hated him, and Phainon was going to cry if there was nothing he could do to fix it. (Internally, of course, as his tear ducts had stopped working as they used to. And because that would be extremely rude.)

"Don't think I've ever seen such a panicked look from you," Aventurine teased with no true joy, "but it's nothing you've done — it's just a me problem."

Phainon kept silent, out of depth in extremely uncharted territory. Oh, he hoped it was just about the terrible matchmaking he'd been doing.

"You haven't told us much about your past — not anything that's made sense, that is." Aventurine began, huddled on the table and seemingly lost in thought, fingers idly tapping against his crossed arms as if waiting for another chip to fall into his hands, "But you have such a noble spirit that it *disgusts* me."

Phainon held his breath, not knowing what to say, but Aventurine barreled on, some buried bitterness smoking like a distant wildfire.

"You were your planet's last hope, its *saviour*." He hissed out the word like it hurt. "Chosen and your people's hopes and wishes were gifted to you, if only because of a vague prophecy or a phoney god's signs. Hah, I imagine it was overwhelming when you got a taste of your destiny. You've gone through hell and endless loneliness and a cruel fate and—"

And, finally, through a rattling, haunted breath: "And you *won*. Everybody lives after your trials and tribulations."

The infected wound known as grief seeped out, even as Aventurine slotted himself back into a doll-like presence, neutral and lifeless.

"I was never alone." Phainon finally spoke, whispering as he knew his voice would break otherwise. He thought of the previous Chrysos Heir who tried to save him from his self-inflicted misery, only to fall minutes later by his own bloody hands. The Nameless, the one catastrophic error he waited and prayed for in Amphroeus' never-ending simulations, "Even when I did the unthinkable countless times over."

Aventurine breathed out, then in, out again. "Apologies, friend. That came out of nowhere."

"It's fine, Aventurine. I'm grateful that you trusted me with your thoughts — no, really! Don't roll your eyes like that," Phainon gently teased. "Besides, I don't think you genuinely hate me at all; I think you're envious."

"Ugh." Aventurine thunked his head against his arms. "You don't have to do this. Just forget about it. Tell yourself it was just a weird dream."

"Well," Phainon drawled, shifting closer, "you've already spilt one secret, might as well spill even more? I think there's another underlying issue here, isn't there?"

Aventurine huffed in annoyance, almost silently, as he was typically one to keep such things hidden. "I don't understand why you decided to push Ratio and I together, you've only known us for such a short while. Is this just some sort of game to you?"

Despite the accusatory sentence, Aventurine sounded anything but that. He seemed to be puzzling out Phainon even as he spoke with a tired look in his eyes that couldn't be solved with rest.

Phainon considered his words. "Maybe at first. No, not quite — despite my levity, it wasn't to humiliate. Across my years, I have seen hopeless love many, many times before. I have fallen in love many, many times — all with the same person I initially never would have considered spending even a day with willingly. Whatever between you two surely isn't unrequited."

As the blond had long since tucked his head between his arms, Phainon could only pinpoint his emotional state as 'not good'.

"You don't seem surprised, but you also refuse to make a move. Ah, well, that's perhaps better than what I did, I used to think Mydei and I were just friends even when he told me to come visit his library in the next life and all the ones to come."

At that, Aventurine finally unfurled, if only to give him an incredulous look.

"… Heavens, you're *stupid*."

"Says the one who refuses to properly make a move on the person they clearly love— ok, care about romantically, is that fine with your delicate emotional state?— because of some weird inferiority and self-hatred complex? Been there, done that, you just end up losing time you could have spent making out instead of pining like a loser."

"Oooh. Ouch. Didn't know ya had it in you."

Silence again. Aventurine picked at the tattered skin of his cuticles; Phainon's leg jumped erratically as he thought.

"It's— I understand becoming miserably bitter when you are nothing left but the blade of an executioner, y'know. Staring down your reflection and remembering how naïve and stupid and good you used to be."

Yet again, yet again, yet again, Phainon thought of Mydei, lovely Mydei, doomed to be a caring soul stuck in the expectations of Strife and bloodlust and rarely being seen as anything other than some barbarian. Mydei never wanted to become Strife, never wanted to rule, but he always held his head high when calamity fell, as he knew there was nobody else who could be a better king. A heavy crown burdened with a heavy fate. (That farmer's boy from Aedes Elysiae wanted to run away the moment his home fell. He wished there was never a need for a Deliverer. He wanted someone stronger to take the role — that did not happen for a long, long time.)

"But gods above, Aventurine, have you ever seen someone so good they inspire you to become better, someone whose eyes you can face in the mirror?"

They stayed silent for a bit longer.

("You know, it would feel pretty good to be a hero of justice once in a while.") Aventurine turned the idea over and over in his head. The whole 'hero of justice' thing was unbearably corny, but Archer did have a point — he was far too used to playing the part of a villain or a caricature of an insane gambler. Despite how badly he hungered for mere scraps of the doctor's affection, he still hesitated. To put it simply, there was a complete 0% chance that Aventurine deserved the doctor or his care.

But if there was one person who could teach him *how*—

(Do stay alive. I wish you the best of luck.)

Oh, he could already tell Ratio would be unbearable; Aventurine wanted him and his unbearable parts so bad his teeth itched. (Goodness, it was much easier to strangle people to death than deal with whatever was going on within himself.) In the end, it would be up to Aventurine to decide if he wanted to take those steps.

Upon noticing that the light was still on, Ratio entered the kitchen, clearly surprised that there were other people up at such an early hour. Once he realised that the likelihood that neither of them had slept at all was far greater, a look of suffering settled in his eyes. Phainon snuck a look at Aventurine, who had migrated into a full sleeping position on the kitchen table, hands resting on his torso as if he were ready for a burial. His eyes were closed, but Phainon knew he'd been fully awake a second ago.

"I like your pajamas." Phainon stated, as they were, indeed, nice sleeping clothes with yellow ducks printed on them, a pleasant blue for the background. "Are you awake enough for some emotions?"

Aventurine's eyes snapped open only to glare up at him.

"Hm. Not for you."

Phainon poked Aventurine in the arm, who had continued to glare at him in bemusement. "No time like the present!" In a whisper, "If you need time, feel free to kick me and I'll get him to back off if necessary."

The young man looked at Ratio with conflicted yearning. "No — I need to do this."

(Ach, he could swear he heard Ratio mutter something like 'finally'.)

Phainon retreated to his room soon, five or so minutes after they went to the top floor, admittedly very, very close to losing any sense of decorum by eavesdropping on them. Aventurine's room should have been on the upper floor, and any shouting should have been audible. If it was quiet in the house, then surely everything was going fine, right? He went to practice his sword forms for a while, kept sharp by his spatial awareness — Phainon was not going to break anything at all, especially when even an amateur appraiser could tell that the idle decorations in the guest bedroom itself were of very high quality.

Eventually, Phainon got bored and hunted down Stelle, reminiscing about the few times he'd been sent to wake up the two Nameless whilst they stayed in Okhema. He knocked on the door, waited for the crusty wailing that signified that the Galactic Baseballer was ready to start the new day. Several thumps heralded her approach, and Phainon smiled sunnily in anticipation of hanging out with her for the day.

"It's 9 in the morning, dude." Stelle croaked out, voice muffled from the blanket she wrapped around her shoulders.

"And it's time to start a new day! Say, why don't we go outside for a bit for a Deliverer-only breakfast!" He offered, wanting to give his host and situationship (hopefully soon turned into actual romantic partner or else Phainon *will* implode) some space, which was likely one of the only tactful things he had done during his stay.

Stelle stepped out of the blanket cloak, revealing the clothes she wore the day before. "Alright then. I'm ready."

The two Deliverers spent their morning in a quaint cafe, peacefully sipping on hot chocolate and enjoying their time spent far, far away from the rush hour overtaking the streets. They swapped stories of what they'd been up to for the past couple of days, speaking of both legends and the mundane.

"…Grammy?"

Phainon nodded. "Grammy fixed me. Well, mostly."

Stelle tried to find a response to that, but chose peace and silence instead, unsure of whether Phainon had met some eldritch abomination in a random massage parlour.

"Do you think she's, like, an Emanator or something?"

"Hmmmm. No, Grammy cannot be contained by our understanding of the cosmos. If anything, she's above such mortal constraints. Even Ena or Qlipoth would struggle to do so. Do you want some more bread? They're pretty decent." Phainon tittered, only to push it onto her plate without waiting for a response.

In the midst of motherhenning, a sense of dread came over Phainon, the fourth piece of bread now dropping between them. Aghast, Phainon whispered, "I have no money. Stelle…?"

Comprehension and its immediate afteraffects were clear in the devastation ripe across her face. "I— Phainon. I'm broke as *fuck*. I'm so sorry."

Stelle's phone pinged.

Aventurine: hello we are going to the club and thenkaraoke later

Aventurine: pleasedo not comeback to my pl\ace no sooner that 16:00

Aventurine: thanks gtgbyeeee

Aventurine has gifted you 500,000 credits.

Chapter End Notes

when i sprinkle in a Ratio can cook agenda into a fic, i also like to think this guy can be a real good baker and that he got into cooking science when he was younger as it's like very practical chemistry lol. I searched up the damn maillard reaction for this, and if there are any readers who know chemistry, sorry if i butchered how it works hah. IDK where the hc with ratio and Polka came from, but trust guys it made sense in my head. She's so cool. I cooked up so many thoughts about that ABO RPF fic if anybody wants to hear about it lmaooo.

Also. For homework, please listen to the totally family friendly Cuppcake song One of My Bedbugs Ate My Pussy. 5 points for anyone who can guess why this will become relevant

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